catradora: our secret place

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27923359.

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Fluff, Smut, catradora, Shameless Smut, everyone is 18+, a few flashbacks to baby catradora, plays around with canon, true to story but reads between the lines, supplemental content really, Switches, Light Bondage, Light Dom/sub, Angst, ok they're both switches, Porn With Plot

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by TheSapphicArcane

Summary

(fluff/smut/angst WiP)

Princess Frosta's first Princess Prom is just around the corner, and Adora is so anxious she can't sleep. She remembers a place in the Whispering Woods only she and Catra knew, a place they visited often when they were kids, especially when they needed to get away from the chaos and noise of the Fright Zone. She decides to visit this secret place in hopes of finally being able to get some peace and quiet, but as it turns out... she's not the only one to have this idea.

aka Catra and Adora find themselves alone together in their childhood safe haven the night before [a more smutty version of] Princess Prom, & things get... interesting.

thanks for reading! enjoy :]

Notes

hey y'all, this is my first fic so go easy on me haha!
thanks for reading, & leave a comment if ya feel like it :]

the treehouse

After finishing their usual post-dinner dessert raid, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow hug in the castle hallway, saying their goodnights.

Glimmer turns around, having forgotten just one thing - "Oh, Adora! I forgot to tell you: Bow and I promised my Aunt Casta we'd drop by tomorrow morning to give our opinions on… some… thing she's decorating? I'm not really sure; she always has… a lot going on. Anyway, you can totally come if you want, but if you'd rather sleep in, that's totally fine - we should be back by lunch-ish."

"Oh, cool - that sounds like the best morning ever, right Bow?" Adora teases, grinning at how Bow is already giving her that *Please save me* look. "...buuut I think I'll sleep in - thanks though. And don't have too much fun without me" she winks, giggling as Bow rolls his eyes so hard he almost almost falls over while turning around.

"Goodniiight, Adoraaa," he groans as he walks away. "Oh, and pray for me tomorrow morning, if you think of it," he whines.

Glimmer laughs, "Mkay, sounds good. Night, Adora, see you tomorrow!" and follows Bow to her room.

Adora changes into her comfy clothes, washes her face, and gets right down to business. She studies the Princess Prom invitation's instructions on proper etiquette for hours once again that night, until she's doubly sure that she knows all the rules backwards and forwards.

Finally ready to sleep, Adora settles into her comfy little cot. But she knows she's not ready to sleep, not even close; she's too anxious - thinking about Princess Prom, worrying about messing

up all the fancy, technical etiquette, running through the steps in her head over and over and over.

Now wide awake, she picks up the scroll again, glancing over the various doodles and illustrations. One illustration, demonstrating the correct handshake guests should use upon meeting strangers, catches her eye. It reminds her of a motion she and Catra used to do as part of the handshake they made up as kids, the "password" to get into a secret treehouse they built on the outskirts of the Whispering Woods all those years ago, when they were 14. Somehow, nobody ever found it, and she had almost forgotten about it until tonight.

Adora sighs, sinking into the memory of the treehouse - remembering how it was their only safe place, the only place they could go to escape Shadow Weaver's watchful eye and be together, away from everyone else, at peace in the cool darkness of the Whispering Woods. They would sit up talking for hours, eating the ration bars they had stolen from Kyle and stashed under their makeshift beds (piles of various fabrics they'd scrounged up and snuck out of the Fright Zone), sometimes cuddling up together until they felt the lull of sleep pulling at their eyelids, heavy and soft and sweet.

And when the sun would rise, its harsh rays would glare in their faces until they awoke with a start, grabbing their packs and rushing back to the Fright Zone as fast as possible.

It was their oldest secret.

Adora thinks about the treehouse and it's softness… gods, it was so soft: even in how it looked, with its soft browns and greens against the rich, colorful backdrop of the Whispering Woods; the soft fabric of the "door" flapping slightly in the gentle woodland breeze; Catra's soft arms brushing against her in the night, her skin… The softest place on earth, she thinks, in a world of sharp edges; of sharp people with sharp tongues.

She looks around at her empty room, suddenly feeling cold and alone. Looking out her window, she stares out at the sea of trees, pausing for a moment before stuffing some blankets in her pack and leaving a note - no, two, because she knows Glimmer will worry - for her friends on the bed.

Stepping over a swell of roots, she ducks and pulls her backpack tighter, continuing on toward the tree house. *What am I doing?* She thinks. *It's probably falling apart by now anyway. Why on Etheria did I think it would be safe enough to spend the night in?!*

Stepping into a slight clearing tucked away on the edge of the woods, Adora hops over a small stream and sets her pack down near the wide, sturdy trunk. After testing quite thoroughly that she won't knock the whole thing off the tree if she attempts to climb up, she throws her pack up through the window and starts climbing. Hoisting herself up to the ledge, she swings her feet over and rolls not-so-gracefully over unto the platform, letting out a heavy breath. She stands and smoothes her wild baby hairs back into place. Pushing the tattered old door-flap aside, she crouches into the treehouse and glances around. Pretty roomy, all things considered - she could totally stretch out on the ground and sleep pretty comfortably.

Interestingly, she notes, the tree has apparently bonded with the floor of the treehouse, so that occasional branches push through the wood and intertwine - no, *mesh* - with the randomly laid floorboards. She smiles, thinking it fit of the Whispering Woods to adopt a random wooden structure into its own giant ecosystem of vibrant life. But even more surprisingly than the treehouse becoming part of the tree is the fact that it's… clean? No, definitely a little dust here and there, but… generally, it looks exactly how it used to. She'd assumed that a family of squirrels would have claimed the shelter by now, or perhaps some bugs might have found solace in its warmth and safety just as she and Catra had. But the place seems generally well kept. *I suppose it hasn't been as long as I think it has since we last came here,*

Adora thinks, sitting cross-legged on the floor to the right of the entrance.

She unrolls her bedding and lays down, watching the branches sway sleepily outside one of the small windows. One arm behind her head, thinking sadly of those safe, cozy nights with Catra, Adora feels her heartbeat slow and her breath deepen. Her limbs relax their tensions, their crimson tightness - and the corners of her eyes smooth.

Looking over the edge of sleep, halfway between worlds (in more ways than one,) Adora shivers at a particularly cold passing breeze and instinctually reaches out to pull Catra closer. Her hand lands with a ***thud*** on the cool wood floor, the pain reverberating up her arm and causing her eyes to fly open. After a brief moment of confused panic, Adora realizes what just happened, bringing back in her arm and holding it close to her stomach - a strange hollowness makes its way into her chest. She doesn't know if she'll feel any warmer tonight.

And then -

"Hey! I heard that! Is someone up there??!" erupts from outside the window. She sits up to see who else has decided to visit this little clearing in the woods, ducking her head out the door.

"Who's there?" Adora calls into the darkness of the woods around her.

Ughhh. This better not get in the way of my good night's sleep. And this is the one chance I get to really sleep in…

"Adora?" Catra's tone sharpens as she steps into the lone sliver of moonlight cutting through the clearing.

"Catra? What are you d-" …but Adora is cut off before she can express to the fullest content her exact level of bewilderment.

"No, the question is what are *you* doing here? Don't you have a pile of sparkly pink pillows to sleep on? Get out, it's mine tonight,"

Catra barks.

"Wait, wha-" Adora rubs her face and gets up, fully aware now, standing in the doorway with surprise and irritation. "Gods, I cannot believe you are here right now … wait, do you still visit this place?"

Catra glares at her, crossing her arms. "I don't see how any of that is *your* business, seeing as you have a real-life castle to sleep in. *Some* of us need the occasional break from Kyle's constant snoring so we aren't tempted to kill him in his sleep. Gods know I barely sleep as it is…" she trails off.

Adora smirks, poking fun at Catra's sudden vulnerability. "What, like you miss me or something?"

Catra doesn't miss a beat, bounding up the tree and landing with a soft **thud** on the wooden floor in a blur of movement, her face suddenly a foot away from Adora's. "I do *not* miss you, okay? Now would you stop being a brat and just give me some space? This conversation is more exhausting than the entire past week of training combined…"

"Wh- *excuse* me? Give *you* some space? Do I need to remind you who was sleeping in here before you barged in and decided everything suddenly belongs to you?"

"Oh *please,* Adora, I would've staked my claim earlier had I known an annoying blonde girl would suddenly need to steal *my* secret spot for her precious beauty sleep!" Catra huffs and begins to unpack, throwing down a sorry excuse for a pillow and a couple blankets to the left of Adora's. There's just enough room for her pack to drop down beside it.

"Catra, I am not leaving just because you sud- wait, did you just call it your 'secret spot'?"

Adora is annoyed and taken aback - touched, almost - at the notion that, deep down, Catra might still care about their dumb little secret hideout in the woods.

Catra looks at her, raising her eyebrows."I mean, after everything that's happened, do you really still expect me to call it ' *our* secret spot,' or… ?"

Adora looks down, feeling scolded and ashamed. Small. "Look, Catra, I-"

"Just - leave me alone, Adora. You can do whatever you want, okay? I don't care. Just leave me alone. I'm going to bed now." Catra turns from Adora, laying on her blankets and curling up tightly into a ball.

Adora stares in shock, marveling at the fact that they aren't throwing punches at each other right now.

What is going on with her? She wonders. *Could she… could she miss me as much as I miss her? Why has she been treating me like she'd rather I die than be in her life again?*

Adora hesitates, looking out the window at the woods. *I really, really, don't want to do that walk again right now…* she groans internally.

You know what? she thinks, suddenly indignant and irritated. *I was here first - Catra can't just intimidate me into leaving because she's annoyed. This is my treehouse, too. I'm staying the night whether she likes it or not.*

Another gust of cool wind rattles the treehouse, and she shivers. She is doing this *out of principle* , she thinks to herself. Yes - it's the *principle* of the thing, she repeats internally. Sure, maybe she'd be warmer, and safer, and comfier at home in her room, but… it's about the *principle* of the thing.

Yes, that's it.

Adora crawls under her blankets, her back to Catra. Catra releases a long, irritated sigh and pulls her blankets closer over her head, realizing that Adora's here to stay for the night.

Adora grumpily repeats *It's the principle* over and over in her mind, closing her eyes and feeling the heaviness of sleep tug on her eyelids almost immediately. She is, after all, just so tired.

Like this they sleep, silent, warm, until around 3am. Midway through the night, a giant hog barges through the clearing, rustling the tree and causing a small storm of leaves to come raining down through the air.

The two girls jolt awake, wide-eyed and ready to punch the nearest living thing in sight. Glancing at each other, and then outside, they realize there's no danger and relax.

"What was that?" Adora ventures.

Catra grunts and lays back down, turning away and pulling her blankets over her ears.

Ever the grumpy one , she thinks. She rolls her eyes softly, laying back down, staring at Catra's back.

Laying there, listening to Catra's soft breath in the dark, she smiles to herself under the blanket. *Our secret spot* , she thinks.

Her eyes trace the shape of Catra's strong, lean shoulder, rising and falling gently in the soft, residual glow of the moon drifting in through the window. Her eyes travel up her shoulder to the gentle curve of her neck, up to her ear, poking out of the blanket in an adorable little bump.

Adorable? No, she means - definitely not adorable, she means - she means dumb. She means that dumb, stupid little bump under the blanket. I mean, it's like, get normal ears like the rest of us, you know?

Adora sighs at herself - a little more loudly than she would've liked, what with her mind on Catra's ears and all.

Catra hears a heavy sigh behind her and opens her eyes, glaring at the side of the room.

"What, Adora."

"Wh-what? I didn't say anything."

"Well you're doing that thing you do where you want to talk but you don't want to say you want to talk so instead you just sigh really loudly to get me to ask 'what's wrong?' or "what's going on?' so… so what's up. Get it out so I can go back to sleep."

"Oh, I -" Adora hesitates, feeling exposed. "I mean," she says slowly, "I guess I was just thinking about earlier. Why did you call this your secret place? As if… as if it was still… something. Something important to you. Catra, do you… do you still come here?"

Catra's eyes widen and she chews her lip, feeling grateful Adora can't see her face. Surely, this isn't really happening. This has to be some sort of weird dream. There is no way she is laying here, in their old treehouse, right next to Adora, considering telling Adora that, yes, she does still come here, almost once a week actually, or whenever she needs to feel close to her again, or whenever she just needs one good night of sleep, or when everywhere else feels so unbearably cold and sharp, and the Fright Zone is much too harsh and bright for a tired heart to find real rest. She opens her mouth, choosing her words very carefully:

"Um… I mean, yeah. Sometimes. Just to make sure animals aren't… living in it. Or messing it up, you know."

Okay, that works.

Adora smiles sadly, wondering if she should tell Catra how often she's thought of her over the last few weeks. Things in the Rebellion have been… good, but, well - new. All so new, so weird. And while she condemns the Horde's actions entirely, there's still a part of her that feels she's been ripped from her home, entirely

uprooted. And no matter how many pink pillows Glimmer throws on her new bed, nothing will ever feel more like home than the memories of this sacred place - with their makeshift blankets, and the cool breeze in the branches, and Catra's slow, hot breath as she drifts to sleep next to her… the occasional brush of Catra's tail on her leg as she readjusts, sometimes holding each other tight through the coldest nights.

A moment passes in silence.

Adora sighs softly. "Thanks."

"For… ?"

"For making sure nothing happens to this place."

Catra pauses a long while, holding her breath. "I didn't want to see this fall apart, too."

***Oh** .*

"I never wanted to leave you, you know," Adora says softly.

Catra furrows her brow, staring at a particular twig sticking out of the wall. She feels the resentment, the deafening grief, rising in her chest. "It doesn't matter now."

Adora gulps. If she doesn't say this now, she probably never will. She figures they'll be at each other's throats until the end of time anyway, so at this point she really has nothing left to lose in being honest.

"Catra, I… y-" she sighs, frustrated at the sentence for not figuring itself out on the way. "You… were the most important person in my life, and I… I really wish you'd join the Rebellion. So much. I think about it… like, kind of all the time."

Catra stiffens, a sudden tear dropping to the soft, wooden floor. "You know I can't do that," she says simply, silently wiping her nose on her sleeve.

“I know that you think that. And you’re allowed to think that. But I just… I miss you. Things aren’t the same without you around. And this still means something to me.” Adora lifts her arm out of the blankets and gestures broadly to their surroundings. “... obviously.”

She hears Catra let out a soft chuckle. “Yeah… I, um - I miss you too, Adora.” Catra winces at herself, at her honesty. What is she doing?

Adora takes a deep breath and considers the consequences of what she does next very carefully. Closing the gap, she scoots closer to Catra - not quite close enough to touch but close enough to feel the warmth radiating from her back - and lays her head just inches away from the back of Catra’s. Immediately she is hit with Catra’s smell, sharp and sweet, and she feels her shoulders reflexively relax.

Catra stares irritatedly at the wall, annoyed more at the fact that she has to figure out what to do and feel in this situation than at what is actually happening.

She closes her eyes and, after a few moments of panicked indecision, decides to scoot back into Adora, savoring the familiar comfort of Adora’s hips pressed against her, framing her against the cold.

When Adora’s arm gingerly drapes over her middle, gentle and firm, her eyes snap open again and she sucks in a sharp breath she hopes Adora didn’t hear. For some reason, her heart pounds in her chest at the sense and weight of Adora’s strong arm around her waist, holding her loosely but securely in its embrace.

A gust of wind rustles the door-flap, the night breeze creeping in under their blankets and pushing them closer. Electric silence echoes off the walls of the treehouse, the air turning thick between them as their bodies press together against the cold, something new and thrilling blooming in the wake of the past.

Adora adjusts her hips and presses them tightly against Catra, wanting to be as close to her as physically possible. She relishes the way Catra's breath quickens under her pull, and then marvels at the fact that they aren't trying to tear each others' throats out right now. Who would've thought she'd ever get to do this again?

And who would've thought it would feel so different, so… *good* this time?

Catra's breathing quickens slightly as Adora gently tightens her arm around her middle. She smiles to herself - *Adora's really here.*

Her stomach tightens at the hot gust of air feathering the baby hairs at the back of her neck when Adora exhales a deep breath, a sudden warmth blossoming in her abdomen, hot and sharp.

She doesn't think about what she does next, just that if she doesn't do it right immediately now she's sure she'll die; that it is suddenly the easiest and most natural thing to do in the world; that it's frankly shocking she hasn't been doing it this whole time.

Breath held in silent hope, Catra rests her hand on top of Adora's in a light grip.

Adora sucks in a sharp breath as Catra's hand envelopes her own. Her mind swims at the unexpected contact, unsure of how to interpret it. Something about this just feels *right* - it always has. Like their bodies were made to slot together like this; like if everything in the world were as it should be, this is where they'd belong: pressed together under the blanket of night, all hot skin and fast heartbeats and the sweet pull of something *more* tugging at the backs of their minds - the jagged edge of something hot slashing through Adora's stomach, an ache that would not be ignored.

Balance all this with a tender, cool-to-the-touch sense of peace, belonging, safety -

The juxtaposition of it all makes Adora's head spin.

Catra's fingers hesitantly intertwine with Adora's, her thumb beginning a slow caress over Adora's skin. A lightning bolt sears through her chest, arcing through her stomach, settling low between her hips.

Her whole body tenses, and she holds her breath as she decides to take a chance - slowly, she moves her upper body closer, closer, until she nuzzles into Catra's thick mane of hair.

She revels in the sweet, warm scent of her, holding her even tighter, savoring the softness of her skin. She tries desperately to soak it all in, to impress it all into her memory so when she goes back to Brightmoon she doesn't forget.

So she can remind herself later that this was - *is* - real.

Overcome by a dizzying sense of wonder, Adora feels her hand move of its own accord – it gently unhooks from Catra's and tentatively begins to draw shapes on her hot tan skin in an almost-caress, occasionally moving to span the length of her forearm.

Catra lets out a soft sigh, almost a moan, before she can stop herself, feeling Adora's hot breath graze her ear, a graceful hand tracing invisible lines up and down her arm, sending heat and energy through her like a flood.

Adora lays in blissful shock, once again marveling at how a person could be this wound up and at peace at the same time. She mumbles softly into Catra's neck, holding her even tighter.

"I missed this."

"Me too."

catra's dream

Chapter Summary

> After falling asleep together, Catra reminisces back to their days as best friends in the Horde. Slipping into a deep sleep, her vivid dream slowly moves further and further away from simple memories, toward imaginings of her innermost desires. Adora wakes her up out of concern, and Catra tries her hardest not to admit that she just fantasized about them becoming much more than just friends.

Chapter Notes

> thank you so much for reading, & leave some feedback if you feel like it - it really does mean the world!
>
> enjoy ;)

"I missed this."

"Me too."

Catra and Adora lay like this, soft arms intertwined, tangled up in each other's warmth.

Adora smiles into Catra's neck as her breathing slows, the two suspended in time and space, finally together again.

Thinking of her past, of *their* past, Catra begins to dream of events long past as she drifts off to sleep…

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Catra looks down at Adora, wiping sweat off her brow and exhaling sharply.

She and Adora are 16, climbing up to their special spot all the way up on the roof - and, once again, Adora is sorely losing the race.

Landing with a reverberating ***clang*** on the platform, Catra rests her hand on her hip and smirks. "Need some help there, slowpoke?"

Adora rolls her eyes and reaches up for a hand, Catra pulling her the rest of the way and helping her to her feet.

"Hey, you have to give me credit - I'm getting faster," Adora pants.

The two girls walk arm in arm to the ledge, Catra perching on the rail as Adora leans next to her.

"Today was fun," Adora comments, staring out at the hazy sky.

Catra stiffens, looking down at her knees. "Yeah, maybe for you and Lonnie."

The cadets had tried a new training exercise that afternoon, with Catra, Adora, and Lonnie showing the most proficiency. The three hung out afterward, Adora and Lonnie chatting up a storm about how epic their last run was.

Adora turns to look at Catra, a look of genuine surprise on her face. "What? What are you talking about?"

"You and Lonnie, Lonnie and you, you know - best friends forever, right?"

"Catra, I-"

"No, it's fine, I get it - she's cool, you guys are… you're cool together. It's fine."

“Catra, stop it,” Adora snaps, then looks at her with tenderness. “You know Lonnie isn’t my best friend. You are. And that’ll never change,” she smiles gently.

Catra lifts her head to look at her, eyes filled with childlike wonder and insecurity. “You promise?”

“Yeah,” she chuckles, “yeah, of course I promise. Catra, you’ve always been so insecure about Lonnie replacing you but… I don’t think you know how much I need you. And I can be friends with Lonnie and still care about you *at the same time* - that doesn’t mean you mean any less to me,” she laughs, flashing Catra that sweet, loving smile. “You should know this by now. You’re mine.”

Catra looks away, trying to hide the crimson heat she could feel rushing to her face.

Mine.

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In a swirl of time and space, Catra’s dream sweeps her up and whirls her away from the land of memories to something entirely different… the deepest parts of her heart, her most secret desires, flood her mind. She gladly gives in to the dream-haze, her brain conjuring up the most sacred, lovely images it could - of her and Adora finally being together in the way she secretly envisions, the way they *should* be together.

Catra surrenders.

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"Mine."

Catra lays on her bunk in the Fright Zone, staring up at the blankness of the ceiling. She furrows her eyebrows.

Quietly climbing down to Adora's bed, she slips under the blanket, spooning tightly against Adora's back. The other cadets are out on a night-shift mission, so it's just them two in the bunks tonight. Catra is grateful for the peace and quiet.

Adora mumbles softly in her sleep, turning around to face Catra with a deep sigh. "Hi. Can't sleep?"

Catra softly shakes her head, nuzzling her head under Adora's chin. Her tail wraps around them both, pulling Adora in even closer.

Adora smiles against Catra's forehead, "Someone's needy tonight."

Catra purrs, a slight rumble against Adora's chest. She pulls her head away after a moment, staring into Adora's face, sharp blue eyes staring back through the darkness. Too tired to combat the notion that she might have needs sometimes, she confesses.

"Yeah, maybe just a little."

Adora moves her head closer, resting her forehead intently against Catra's. "I'm feeling a little needy too," she confesses.

"Yeah?" A pause. "Needy for what?"

Silence.

"You." Adora's voice is steady and low, barely audible.

Catra feels her cheeks flush. She's flustered, trying not to show it. "And what... what does that mean, exactly?"

"I think you already know," Adora says, voice low, eyes piercing and intent through the dark haze of night.

Catra glances down at Adora’s lips, soft and full. What is happening right now? Could she mean…?

Adora wraps an arm around her waist, slipping her thigh in between Catra’s, applying gentle pressure - just enough to flood Catra’s insides with sudden heat.

“Adora, what're y-” Catra sighs, looking back up into Adora’s eyes.

Staring down with a slight smirk, Adora moves her face until her lips are mere centimeters away from Catra’s.

“I want you.”

Catra’s eyes widen as she feels a delicious ache in her chest, an insatiable desire to give herself to Adora, body and soul; to be claimed and taken as her own, to be hers completely.

Denying her the kiss, Adora's mouth moves lower, slowly making its way down Catra’s body; her lips trailing lightly over Catra’s skin - down her chin, her jawline, under and behind her ear, down to the base of her neck.

Catra feels Adora’s hot breath against her skin - her stomach tightening, electricity racing out through her limbs, her thighs clenching around Adora's involuntarily.

Adora begins to softly kiss her neck, slowly at first and getting more aggressive with time; her hand slides down to graze Catra’s upper thigh over her sweats.

Catra lets out a breathy moan, tilting her head back, ecstasy racing through her veins. She feels her thighs clench around Adora’s leg, her hips pulled into a slow grind. Kissing her neck a little harder now and leaving the occasional mark on her tan skin, Adora’s hand trails slowly down her chest, her fingertips dragging across the warm skin beneath the bottom of her shirt. Catra gasps, her body shuddering as her hips press needily against Adora’s thigh, somehow feeling needier by the second.

Reaching for Adora’s hand, Catra impatiently moves it toward the waistline of her sweats, hoping for Adora to draw circles on her skin maybe *a little bit lower this time.*

Adora’s hand resists her hints, her eyes rising to meet Catra's.

“Looks like you want something,” she says with a smirk.

“A-adora, please -”

“Ooo, gonna have to work a little harder than that,” she teases.

“Adora,” Catra pants against her mouth, voice slightly breathless and embarrassingly desperate - “just fuck me. Now. Please-”

“Hm,” Adora raises an eyebrow, slowly slipping her hand underneath Catra’s waistband.

Catra lets out a soft moan against Adora’s mouth as she feels Adora’s hand make its way under her waistband, fingertips gliding over her soft skin, slowly and with purpose, eventually finding their way down to her entrance.

Adora stops again, teasing Catra as she shivers with anticipation.

“Here?”

“Mmh,” Catra nods her head, utterly helpless to Adora’s every move, her body craving Adora’s fingers, her lips, her heat, her everything.

It was finally happening.

“I’ll take that as a yes,” Adora says, her fingers slowly parting Catra's entrance, one slowly dipping down into her.

“My, my, what happened down here?”

lowering her lips to Catra’s neck again, Adora teases her tongue over her skin, sometimes giving a little nibble or a soft (ish) bite.

Catra, entirely able to speak, shudders at Adora's intoxicating touch, utterly helpless to her fingers and their magic. She grinds her hips against Adora again, deeper this time.

Adora slips her fingers over Catra's entrance a few times, gathering Catra's wet on her fingers and pausing again to slowly raise her hand up to her mouth. Staring down at Catra with a gaze of steel, she slowly inserts her fingers into her mouth, having Catra suck them clean before returning them to between her thighs.

Circling Catra's clit for a few moments, Adora's fingers make their way down to her entrance, teasing her with slight inserts, Catra's hips bucking slightly with every pulse.

"A-adora," she moans, eyes squeezed shut, her neck beginning to glisten with a thin layer of sweat as she releases a pleading sigh.

"Hmm?"

"Pl- ah… please… just - just fuck me already."

Adora slips a finger into Catra's soaking wet entrance, eliciting a sharp gasp. Working her fingers faster and faster, she finds Catra's spot and pumps in and out, pulling sweet moans from Catra's throat a little more loudly now as her muscles tense, pulling Adora in.

Writhing in pleasure, Catra's hips grind down onto Adora's hand, like waves against the base of a cliff. Her body floods with euphoria, and with a shiver, she pulls Adora in closer.

"More," she pleads.

Adora slows down slightly to add another finger.

Catra can't help but let out a satisfied groan, continuing to roll against Adora's busy hand.

"Gods, you're so wet," Adora sighs.

“A-ahh…” is all Catra can manage to get out, her body so on fire with pleasure.

“Then again, I knew you would be,” Adora smirks, taking her fingers out, watching Catra desperately continue to grind through her sweats against Adora's thigh.

“Take them off. Now,” Adora says, tugging at the waistband of Catra’s sweatpants. Catra nods hurriedly, shimmying off her sweats and throwing them on the floor.

“Perfect,” Adora sits up, swinging her leg over Catra so she’s straddling her waist, looking down with a raised eyebrow.

Maintaining eye contact, Adora slowly leans forward and begins kissing down Catra’s torso, stopping at her underwear band.

Catra leans her head back, feeling Adora’s hot breath against her skin. She can feel how wet she’s gotten, having soaked almost completely through her underwear, and she's desperate to have Adora inside her again.

Kissing down her underwear, Adora slides aside the fabric until she is face to face with her entrance. Teasing her with a few slow licks, Adora wraps her arm up and around her leg and begins tracing lines down her torso, up her thighs, around her lower abdomen. Almost panting out moans now, Catra’s hands grip the course blankets, her hips rising to meet Adora’s touches.

Speeding up her tongue, Adora gets to work. Catra grinds against her, panting as she grips the sheets even tighter.

Catra holds out as long as she can before sighing a breathy “Fuck -”

The euphoria swells between her thighs, her body rolling, legs tensing and quivering, face burning red, neck shimmering with a slight layer of sweat, something intoxicating blossoming somewhere deep in her abdomen, somewhere deep -

“Fuck… fuck… ahh- fuck- Adora, I’m-”

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Catra awakes with a startle, the weight of a hand on her shoulder shaking her gently.

“Catra? You okay?”

“Wh-what?” Catra asks, panicked and embarrassed.

“Just seemed like you were having a, uh… a really vivid dream for a little bit there. You okay?” Adora shyly inquires.

Catra turns over, meeting Adora’s innocent, curious eyes.

“Yeah, I’m fine, I was just… I had a weird dream.” she tries to think of a relatively believable lie as quickly as possible while Adora gives her that adorable confused face she always does. “We… we were up o-”

Adora cuts her off, “Hey, you don’t have to tell me anything; I didn’t mean to pressure you. I just wanted to make sure you’re okay, cause you were kind of moving - like… kind of a lot. And I was just worried.” She smiles, gently placing a hand on Catra’s shoulder, feeling her stiffen. “That’s all.” She turns to lay down again.

Catra breathes a silent sigh of relief that Adora somehow didn’t catch onto the fact that she was unconsciously fantasizing about her. *Gods, that was close...* She smiles nervously and closes her eyes.

The two lay in silent tension a moment, Catra praying they could just go to sleep and forget all about this.

“I mean, sounded like whatever was happening in that dream… you were pretty invested in it…” Adora says out of nowhere, letting out a soft chuckle to herself.
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Fuck.

Catra's eyes snap open. She stares at the ceiling, filled with cold dread.

"Ahh, yeah. Kinda. There was... a lot going on," she tries to keep her voice steady. Then she notices she's still wet - in real life - and groans at how her brain has tricked her. "Just another weirdly vivid dream, you know me." she cringes at herself. Just stop talking Catra! Gods! Shut up!!

"Well, what was it about…?" Adora presses.

Fuck. She thinks. *Of course Adora won't really let this go.*

"It was just about, like, us… back in the Fright Zone. Nothing important," she says flatly.

"Hm. What were we doing?" Adora wonders innocently.

Gods damn it, Adora. I'm going to say things you might not like and it's going to be your own fault for forcing it out of me. Do you ***ever*** *give up? Just this once, maybe? Please?*

"We were… sitting up on the roof, talking about stuff. Just the usual. And then…"

Adora turns to look inquisitively at Catra, eyes illuminated by the hazy slivers of moonlight peeking in through the windows.

"... then we had a sleepover and... talked. That's it. That's the whole dream. Now will you please go to bed?"

"Aww, I remember our sleepovers," Adora smiles. "What were we talking about?"

"Nothing!! Gods! Now would you please-"

"Hey, woah, I didn't mean to piss you off or anything, I was just curious…" Adora pauses, worry creeping onto her face. "Were we,

like, arguing or something?" she asks solemnly.

Catra sighs, helpless to Adora's adorable (and at times annoying), stubborn curiosity. "No. We weren't arguing."

Adora pauses for a moment, silently thinking it all over. A thought hits her, and after initially dismissing it as too unlikely to be at all possible, she returns to it, letting it swim curiously and pleasantly through her mind.

"So we weren't talking, and we weren't arguing…" Adora's eyes narrow, lifting a curious eyebrow as she continues. "Catra, did you dream that we-"

"Adora!" Catra yelps, throwing her hands over her ears and turning away.

"What?? It's not an unreasonable assumption! We're together again, which is… weird… and you're probably just thinking about it so much that your brain just doesn't know what to do with it," Adora pauses, a hot blush slowly creeping onto her cheeks. "I mean, I've-"

"Adora, stopppp talkingggg," Catra groans, burying her head in her pillow. "I am not talking about this anymore. Goodnight."

Adora's face lights up with victory. "So you DID have a spicy dream about us! Ha! I was right!"

Catra moans, peeking out from her pillow. "You're not going to let this go until we talk about it, are you?"

Adora raises an eyebrow, smiling deviously.

"Ughhhhhh. Okay. Fine. Yes. I dreamed about us in a… a *different way* this time. You happy now? Do with that what you will."

"I mean, I'm not necessarily surprised," Adora teases, scooting in closer to Catra's exasperated expression.

“What?” Catra blushes, feeling defensive but excited at Adora’s comment.

“I mean,” Adora’s voice shakes as she continues, “it’s not like we… like we haven’t ever thought about it before, right?” she trails off, voice suddenly tender.

“I-” Catra is speechless. Her heart races as she tries to find a way out of the corner she’s found herself in.

“Look, I’m just saying: either I’m crazy, or this… at some point… could’ve been - I don’t know - *something* . Something... else.” Adora blushes, lightly pushing a lock of hair out of Catra’s stunned face. “I mean. Right?” she says weakly.

Catra inhales sharply at the feeling of Adora’s fingers against her cheek, her ear… this is just all too much. Adora’s sweet face, the warmth of her body, her soft, curious voice - it was all too much. Nothing else matters now, nothing but Adora’s lips, her hands, the tension of her body getting dangerously close to Catra’s.

Adora, panicking at Catra's silence, blurts out, "Or maybe that was all in my head, just - just forget about it."

Catra sighs. *What the hell. Here we go.*

Catra’s eyes harden with intent. It’s now or never. Pulling Adora closer, she cups her face in her palms, enjoying the obvious surprise and blush creeping onto her face.

Lightly pressing herself against Adora, Catra hesitantly bites her lip as the two girls’ bodies awaken to what’s happening.

Adora, wide-eyed and paralyzed by disbelief, lets out a soft exhale only inches from Catra’s face.

The two hold this tension for what feels like forever, soaking up the feeling of being pressed together, the warmth and anticipation building in their stomachs, tentative hands starting to wander

softly over the other's skin, all the while staring intently into each other's eyes, searching for a sign to stop.

Catra leans in, now only a fraction of an inch away from Adora's face. Staring at Adora's lips, she lets out a hot breath and lightly brushes her top lip over Adora's. In a low voice, she murmurs,

"Wanna know what else happened in my dream?"

the way things are

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora grapple with the reality of their situation as tension builds and uncomfortable truths come to light.

(Character/emotion-driven chapter)

Chapter Notes

for now it's all about the build up, baby ;]

as always, i love love love your feedback!! thanks so much for reading!

"Wanna know what else happened in my dream?"

"I… wh-" Adora stammers, hearing her own voice shake.

"What? Cat got your tongue?" Catra purrs, loving how caught off guard Adora is. The blush forming on her cheeks is just… *ugh.* Delicious. And the way her eyes widen every time Catra even *looks* at her? Catra could get used to this kind of power…

Adora blushes. *I wish,* she thinks, recalling the brief softness of Catra's upper lip. "N-no, I- I just…"

God, Adora, just spit it out already so we can move onto the fun part.

"I just can't believe this is… this is really happening, that's all," she says, eyes wide with shock, her face mere centimeters away from Catra's. She kicks herself inside for ruining the moment, for

breaking the delicious tension between them - and winces when Catra pulls back slightly in concern. *Of course I had to go and ruin it… Damn it, Adora, when are you gonna learn to shut up?!*

"I know… me neither, honestly"

Adora feels her cheeks get hot, savors the hopeful look on Catra's face as she pulls a little closer. "It's just that… whatever hope I previously had for this to happen kind of..." she hesitates. "Kind of disappeared when I- when things… changed." She smiles sheepishly.

Catra's face hardens slightly, her expression giving away just how much the memory of Adora leaving still affects her. She feels a sharp sorrow well up in her chest, and can't help but look away.

"Look, Adora, I…" Catra feels heat rising in her chest, the anxiety of impending vulnerability. Her body screams for Adora, craves her heat, wants her pressed against her, wants to hear her breathy voice cry her name, beg for her…

But her heart - oh, her heart - Adora has this way of just ripping it open, exposing Catra's true feelings to the harsh light of truth, pulling stupid confessions out of her mouth without even trying. And that scares Catra. A lot.

Adora has always been like this, though - capable of melting Catra's walls with a single sentence, giving her that look - that stupid, sweet, warm smile - and turning Catra into a pile of gooey feelings and - ugh - *tenderness.*

Catra bites her lip, still unable to look Adora in the eyes. She feels the initial resistance - the instincts screaming at her to shut up and play it cool, to deny the truth of the connection between them, to land a jab about Adora's betrayal, to add another layer to the walls she's built around herself. But Adora… Adora deserves the truth. She deserves something real. Just this once. Maybe never again, but just this once.

“Yeah, I don’t really know how to say this,” Catra starts, feeling Adora’s worried stare bore into her. “But since you brought it up, honestly things have been… stressful… since you left, and I just… I find myself thinking about you. Sometimes. And I think that… you’re right. At some point, this could’ve been something… more. And I would've really liked that,” Catra gulps, feeling herself slipping. A crack forms in the wall, tremoring and threatening to grow. “And…” Catra bites the inside of her cheek as she feels her eyes begin to water. They sting as she holds back bitter tears.

She said it earlier, but not the way she really wanted to - not to the extent to which it was true.

“Adora, I… I really, really miss you. Like, for real. Like, more than I thought I would.”

Adora’s eyebrows raise as she feels Catra press into her chest. Her head nuzzles its way under her chin, Catra still avoiding meeting her eyes. Catra winces at her heartfelt confession, feeling stupid, holding her breath for Adora’s response.

Adora stares blankly into the darkness in shock. *She… she actually misses me? Like, for real? And she* ***admitted*** *it? Out loud, just now, to my face? She's... serious?*

The reality of the situation begins to sink in as she holds Catra tighter, noticing how tense Catra’s back muscles feel against her arms. This is really torturing her.

“Catra, I… I miss you too. So much. Every day, actually. It... it kills me. I mean I love my new friends and all, but... it's not the same without you around."

Back muscles relax against Adora’s hands as Catra melts into her tight embrace.

Adora is suddenly overcome with a powerful surge of excitement, her body jolting a little as she excitedly exclaims -

“Come with me! Back to Bright Moon, in the morning! Catra, I know you hate the Fright Zone as much as I did, and I know I've already asked, but really - there’s still time for things to change! It’s not too late f-” she’s interrupted by a push against her chest.

“You think I can just leave?” Catra pulls away and stares at her, shock and bitterness splayed across her damp face. “You think I can just - what - go back and grab all my stuff and walk out the door? Yeah, and maybe on my way out I’ll just pop into the Black Garnet Chamber for a sec to let Shadow Weaver know I’m switching sides! I’m sure she’ll give me a tender little kiss on the head and wish me luck on my new journey of *finding myself* ” her voice cracks on the second-to-last word, a hot tear rolling down her face against her will.

Adora stares in shock. Catra’s… right, honestly. And it breaks her heart to think about it. But what really twists the knife is the look on Catra’s face: anger, of course - but, more than that - *fear.* Catra is *deeply* afraid. She always has been. At the core of this cocky, ruthless warrior is a dense ball of *fear,* now threatening to unravel and come undone within her chest. Fear: always fueling her rage and smugness, constantly reminding Catra that she needs to *survive* first and foremost.

Adora briefly thinks back to the time Shadow Weaver took her aside and asked her, a young child at the time, whether the Horde should keep Catra on as a cadet or… or *dispose* of her. Adora remembers her little heart racing, not because she didn’t have an answer (obviously) but because Shadow Weaver stared at her with such *sincerity* that Adora didn’t even for a second suspect she was joking.

Catra was - *is* - afraid . And for a pretty damn good reason, too. Adora can’t really blame Catra for looking out for her physical safety before anything else - Catra has had to learn how to protect herself against the horrors of the reality of living in the Horde, and Adora knows that. She watched it happen.

She looks at Catra, at her eyes, illuminated by the stray moonlight, vivid yellow and blue in the dark - looking at Adora with such intensity and helplessness.

Her heart sinks with the dreaded realization: *Catra is not switching sides. Not now, not ever.*

This is it.

Her chest aches at the thought that they'll have to keep on like this until one of them finally defeats the other. She really thought she could bring her home this time.

The two lay in silent understanding, chests rising and lifting in the hazy moonlight. They both know Catra has a valid point. Shadow Weaver would know she was leaving for good, would sense it from a mile away - would track her down with her shadow spies and, once Catra was once again within her grasp, do *gods* -know- what to her. Adora getting away was a fluke, an error - a miscalculation.

And Shadow Weaver was trying desperately to get her back because she *liked* her - with Catra it would be much, much different.
Catra and Adora stare at each other through the darkness, the gravity of the situation settling between them in an unspoken realization that they will never be together - not the way they could be.

Not in the way they both know they should be.

This is just the way things are. Better for them both to accept it and move on with their lives.

"I'm sorry," Adora says simply. She thinks longingly back to when Catra almost kissed her, a mere five minutes ago - well, more like a lifetime now that she's driven a chasm between them by pushing Catra to join her. What an idiot she was for ruining the moment - she should've just kept her mouth shut and let things go where they would've. Now she's inches away from her Catra,

but not in the way she wishes she were, and the moons will be rising in a few hours, and then they'll both have to go home and pretend like the other person is the real enemy, instead of the world that tore them apart in the first place.

"Don't be sorry," Catra responds blankly.

Adora feels the floor shudder as Catra's walls slam shut again with a thunderous ***bam*** .

"Really, don't," Catra continues. "I mean, us being… anything other than what we are… was never really in the cards anyway." Her voice has a stoic sorrow in it. Like this is just the way the world goes.

"Well," Adora concludes. She has to give it one last shot. "If you ever find a way out from under Shadow Weaver's thumb… you know where to find me," she says with a sad smile. "No matter what happens, I'll always miss you."

Silence. Then - Catra squeezes her eyes shut, and in one quick movement - so quick Adora can barely register what's happening until it's already over - Catra scoots forward and presses a hot, tender kiss to the border of Adora's mouth, leaning into it for a few seconds, inhaling deeply against Adora's soft skin. Immediately afterward, before Adora can respond or pull Catra in for a real kiss, Catra whips around and pulls the blanket up high around her head.

Message received.

Smiling to herself but feeling her chest ache with longing at the same time, Adora turns around too, snuggling her face into the blankets that now feel all-too-cold, all-too-empty without Catra's warm body pressed up against hers.

The two lay in silence a while, both processing the situation with resigned neutrality.

As Adora finally closes her eyes, praying for the sweet embrace of sleep to sweep her up and away from this crazy night, she feels a slight movement behind her.

Catra's tail snakes under her blanket, searching fervently in the dark for its target, eventually brushing against Adora's backside and wrapping tightly around her upper thigh. She gives Adora's thigh a squeeze, caressing up her softly with the tip of her tail as she pulls it back over to her side of the treehouse.

Adora smiles to herself in the dark. She reaches a hand up to her face, pressing her palm against the corner Catra kissed, trying to remember and savor the feeling of being hers.

The wind rustles the branches outside the window as they both fall into a deep sleep.

When Adora awakes, Catra is gone.

She isn't surprised. To be honest, she half expected to wake up to a squadron of Horde soldiers waiting outside to greet her.

She sits up and rubs her eyes, resting her face in her hands for a moment while her memory familiarizes itself with the events of the night before.

She and Catra almost kissed - no, more specifically, *Catra* almost kissed *her* .

She inhales sharply as she remembers their conversation about Catra leaving the Horde and coming back to Bright Moon with her. Her heart sinks as she pushes away the thought of Catra sleeping by her feet on the cot in her room at Bright Moon, the pale sunrise peeking over the horizon, Catra's soft purrs vibrating up the mattress as Adora sleepily strokes her ears and neck to wake her up…

Adora shuts her eyes, hating herself for even entertaining such a lovely but devastatingly unrealistic wish.

Grabbing her pack so she can stuff what she can into it and head home, she finds a wrinkled note laying just inside the mouth of the empty main pocket.

"careful, floorboard near the door almost tripped me on my way out. i'll fix it when i can. -C"

Adora sets the note down and glances toward the door, noticing a floorboard jutting up and out from the already uneven ground. Smiling to herself and throwing the note at the bottom of her pack, she clambers down the tree. Not really one for grace or finesse, her feet hit the ground with a hard ***thud*** . She inhales the rich smell of the woods and lets out a long sigh, wondering what Catra was doing at this very moment.

"Wanna know what else happened in my dream?"

Adora shakes her head, trying to forget the velvety growl of Catra's voice last night, the soft brush of her upper lip against hers, the hot electricity emanating from between her legs up through the rest of her limbs, the prominent, gentle curve of Catra's jaw in the shadows.

The walk back to Bright Moon is long and silent.

princess prom

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra find some time to be alone at Princess Prom.

Chapter Notes

hey guys! sorry I haven't updated in a while, life has been pretty crazy.
since it's been a while, I thought I'd make it up to you with an extra long chapter :]

things will heat up even more over the next few chapters, & I'm so so excited for you to read them!
enjoy :]

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The walk back to Bright Moon is long and silent.

Adora sends her pack flying across the room, watching it slide across the floor and slump against her bedpost.

She walks over to the mirror, stares at her reflection - her wrinkled shirt, the small bits of twig stuck in her hair - proof that what just happened was real.

She smiles as she thinks back to when she and Catra were young cadets in the Horde, how they'd help the other pick out the twigs and forest bits from their hair and fix up (hopefully before they ran into Shadow Weaver) whenever they got back from having spent a night out in the treehouse. They'd slip in past the guards, giggling and shushing each other through the Fright Zone's vents, landing deftly back in the barracks. It was usually barely after the first moonrise when they'd slip under the covers again, and so

they'd almost always have another half hour to lay there and giggle before the morning alarm sounded.

Such was their sacred ritual of reintroducing themselves to the reality of life in the Horde, of setting aside the dream-world that lived on the outskirts of the forest: cloaked by the trees, blanketed in the all-too-rare comfort and peace of privacy.

After gently brushing off rogue bits of forest from her shoulders, Adora turns form the mirror. She falls back onto her bed, sinking into bittersweet memories, remembering back to one of the mornings she and Catra had snuck back into Horde territory after a night in the woods.

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"Come onnnn, hurry up!" Catra groans, holding aside a vent cover.

The two are around fifteen years old (of course, who knows for sure; it's not like they have birthdays to remind them...) and are returning to the Fright Zone after a night in their secret place.

"Do you *want* to get caught?" Catra hisses, playful sass twisting her face.

"I'm - coming - just," Adora pants, jogging up to the vent opening, "- slow *down!* Geez!"

"Maybe *you* should speed up - not my fault you're the slowest person on Etheria," she smirks, ducking into the vent. Adora rolls her eyes, crouching in after her.

Hazy moonlight slowly seeps in through the barracks' small windows as a vent cover near the floor slowly slides out of place.

The two girls tiptoe back over to their bed. Adora climbs under the blankets first, sighing softly as her head meets the flattened pillow. Catra curls up by her feet, her nose nestled into the crook
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of her arm. The two let their heart rates settle for a moment, breathing heavily together in the soft moonlight. They smile to themselves, feeling proud of yet another secret mission accomplished without anyone ever having a clue what they were up to.

Adora looks down at Catra, smiles when she sees her face tucked so snugly into the crook of her arm. She thinks about how Catra very well could've chosen to sleep in her own bed, especially now that they'd had their teenage growth spurts (not to mention the fact that they had the whole barrack to themselves since Lonnie was in the infirmary with a broken leg for the next month). She's sure Catra would be more comfortable just being able to sprawl out and have a whole bunk to herself, but for some reason she chooses Adora's, night after night, month after month. She secretly hopes Catra would never leave, would never wise up to the fact that it just made more sense for them to sleep apart. She hopes, somewhere deep inside, they could just stay like this forever. It just felt *right.*

Her hand slides down the blanket and strokes behind Catra's ears, her reward a soft purr rumbling the bottom half of the bunk. Adora shivers with satisfaction, like she always does when Catra purrs - especially when it's because of her.

They stay like this for a while, until Adora's fingers get caught in a thick tangle of hair, and when she tries to comb through it Catra lets out a soft yelp. The purring ceases as Catra wiggles her way up next to Adora, and once they're face to face it's obvious she's irritated at having had to move out of her comfortable position to express her discontent in a harsh whisper:

"What the hell, Adora, do you *want* me to go bald? Just take a fistful why don't ya?!"

"Oh calm down, it was just a small tangle from something I must've missed earlier - see?" Adora holds up a crooked twig and tosses it behind her bunk. "No need to be so dramatic," she teases, enjoying the annoyed crinkle between Catra's eyes and

her stubborn silence. “Fine, maybe I just won’t touch your hair at all then, have it your way.”

“W-wait -” Catra’s eyes widen, her indignant demeanor melting away in a moment of vulnerability.

“Ohhhh that’s right - I’m sorry, I forgot brushing your hair turns you into a purring little kitten!” Adora teases excitedly.

“Shut *up* ! It does not!!”

“Yeaaahhhhh gonna have to disagree on that one,” Adora giggles. “You melt like butter when I touch your ears, it’s too easy.”

Catra feels her cheeks get hot when she’s hit with the exhilarating realization: Adora likes when she purrs?

She snaps back into character. “Yeah, well, whatever - you don’t know what you’re talking about,” she scoffs, rolling her eyes.

Adora sees that she might’ve pushed Catra a bit too hard and possibly embarrassed her. Her tone softens as she gingerly places her hand under Catra’s shoulder, pulling her closer. “Catra, wait - I’m sorry, I was just kidding. I actually really like when you purr with me. It makes me feel like… like you trust me. Like I’m special to you.”

Catra furrows her eyebrows, trying to keep her face from giving her away.

“Here,” Adora continues, “just flip over and let me keep combing through your hair. Since I guess I didn’t do a very good job the first time.”

Catra huffs as she turns around. “ *Fine* , but don’t yank on it, or I’ll kill you.”

She smiles to the wall now that Adora can’t see the contentment on her face.

"Okay, fine, your Majesty, I'll be gentle," Adora agrees.

She begins to comb her fingers through Catra's wild locks, picking out random tidbits of the Whispering Woods she'd missed earlier and tossing them behind her bed. Catra seems to release some of the tension in her shoulders, relaxing into Adora's touch, trusting that Adora would never hurt her if she could help it.

After a few minutes of combing, Adora's fingers slow as her eyelids begin to get heavy. Now lazily running her fingers through Catra's hair, she savors the velvety coolness in between her fingers. She starts her strokes right at the base of Catra's ears, giving them a soft graze every time she raises her hand for another comb-through.

She thinks to herself that she could do this forever. Part of her wishes Lonnie would never come back, that they'd never graduate to the Upper Grade barracks, that it could just be her and Catra in here forever. She glances over to their crude self portraits on the wall of the bunk, remembering fondly the day they drew them. Her hand begins to scratch light circles around Catra's head before slowly burying her hand in the brunette's thick hair and stroking down, down, down.

Maybe home isn't the treehouse, she thinks; maybe it's Catra.

Adora grins as she feels the beginnings of Catra's purr, a low rumble against her chest. She lifts her hand to her ears, tracing lazy circles down the side of her head and dragging her fingertips to the base of her neck, slowing to gentle caress on the tops of Catra's bare shoulders. Adora hesitantly explores the hot, tan skin with her fingertips, tracing patterns in Catra's freckles. She silently marvels at the fact that anyone could be this incredibly *soft* .

Adora's breath hitches in her throat as Catra's purrs intensify and her tail wiggles against Adora's thighs, eventually wrapping around Adora's shin and pulling her closer. She enjoys knowing that she has this effect on Catra, that Catra feels comfortable enough to let her guard down and let Adora comfort her

physically. She feels special being the only one Catra purrs against.

A warmth grows in the cavern of her chest and she is overcome with tenderness, flooded with familiar feelings of closeness, of vulnerability. The world outside seems to soften and disappear as Catra melts into a soft, sleepy, purring mess in her arms, leaning ever so slightly into her touch, pressing back into her without making it obvious she wants to be held. Adora gets the hint and wraps her arms around Catra's middle, breathing in a sigh against her bare shoulder.

After a few minutes, Adora feels Catra's body shift, rolling over in her arms.

Catra's eyes are still closed as her face nestles underneath Adora's chin. "Hey Adora?" she asks softly into her chest.

"Yeah?" For some strange reason, Adora's heart is racing.

"Do you ever feel like -" Catra pauses.

"Like… what?"

"Like… like there's worms in your stomach? Like you're a little sick but in a good way?"

Adora's blushes as she thinks about the current warmth in her chest. "Yeah, sometimes. Like your stomach gets warm and nervous?"

"Yeah. You get that too?"

"Sometimes, yeah. I don't think it's a *bad* thing though. Just feels… weird."

"Hm. Yeah, I just… wanted to know if it was just me."

Adora readjusts her chin on top of Catra's head. "No, I get that too. Usually when I'm happy or sleepy."

“Yeah,” Catra hesitates. “Like… like right now you mean?”

“I mean… yeah.” Adora feels her heart pounding in her chest. She starts to feel lightheaded but the feeling in her stomach drowns it out, anchors her to the present moment. It feels like all her senses are dialed up to 11; she’s overly aware of every single one of Catra’s movements, no matter how small. She feels every point of contact their bodies are making - every inch of touch. Her heart threatens to burst out of her chest, racing around her ribcage, flooding her body with euphoria. She has to remind herself not to hold her breath. “Yeah, I guess I feel them right now,” she says decidedly.

“Hmm.” Catra hums, pressing herself into Adora’s chest. “Do you like it?” she asks nervously.

Adora takes a deep breath, letting her body go completely lax against Catra’s.“Yeah, I think I do.”

The silence envelops them, blanketing the room with a tender understanding that doesn’t need to be put into words.

The two girls sink into a lovely, dreamlike twilight zone, holding each other tight until the morning alarm tears them away from their blushing stupor.

They never speak of it again.

~~~

Adora sits up with a start, snapping back into reality.

Her blood turns to ice as she sees the long invitation scroll tacked up on her wall.

Princess Prom.

~~~

Adora and Glimmer lean over the edge of the balcony handrail, looking out over Frosta's grand ballroom: the Prom guests are happily swaying and walking and eating and talking, lost in their own universes. Adora does her best to comfort a desheleveled, insecure Glimmer - reassures her that her friends will never abandon her, never leave her behind…

It hits her like a ton of bricks.

She squints, leans forward - just to be sure.

Yep. It's her.

It's Catra.

At the Prom.

The Princess Prom.

Are you *fucking kidding* me?

And she's in a *suit* ? Oh, come ***o n*** .

Adora tries desperately to warn Frosta, but she won't listen. Of course she doesn't believe her. She does sound crazy, after all - a paranoid lunatic essentially begging for them to kick Catra out for no reason. Adora can barely contain her frustration and panic.

She groans as she and Glimmer split up to follow their respective suspects.

After a solid 20 minutes of trailing behind Catra and watching her every move, Adora follows her down a corridor to the side of the

ballroom. It seems to have a few doors on each side, all closed and seemingly off limits to guests.

"What are you doing?" Adora asks flatly, cautiously.

"Uhh, going to pee? What's it look like, genius?" Catra gestures vaguely to the Restroom sign at the end of the corridor.

"Oh," Adora mutters, embarrassed.

She follows Catra into the restroom, crossing her arms while she waits by the sinks.

"You know," Catra says, washing her hands and looking over to Adora with a smirk, "I knew you missed me, but I didn't realize you'd be stalking me all night. Maybe I should've come as *your* plus one instead of Scorpia's. Although we both know you're too embarrassed to admit you like me." She stares at Adora, maintaining smug eye contact as she throws the dampened paper towel in the trash.

Adora feels her ears get hot; crimson rage boiling in her chest - she has half a mind to smack that stupid smirk off Catra's face herself.

"I'm only *following* you because it's so obvious that you're not really here for the Prom, Catra. You're here to mess things up, and honestly, why am I even surprised at this point? That's what you *do* !"

Catra frowns, secretly hurt by the notion that Adora only ever sees her as messing things up. She was also irritated that Adora was right - she *did* intend to mess things up.

But that's none of her business anyway, so shut up.

Doing her best to collect herself as she heads back out into the hall, Catra smooths her hair back and grins, calling over her shoulder:

"Oh please, princess, we both know you're not as disappointed to see me as you say you are… besides, you'd do *anything* to see me in this suit again."

Adora angrily blushes as she silently follows Catra out of the restroom, thinking back to the time their squadron first learned the formal dances together.

Every night for a month, the group of 5 would find an empty storage room to hang out in after dinner and practice for hours, laughing and tripping over each other until they got tired and returned to the barracks. Kyle had apparently pestered an older cadet to show him the moves to all the basic dances, and he insisted on teaching everyone else at their secret meetings. He would also refuse to dance with anyone but Rogelio for some reason, and because Lonnie wasn't one for dancing and just came to watch, Catra and Adora always ended up as partners.

(They didn't mind.)

When Catra first got the burgundy suit she wore it nearly every time they all met up to dance - sauntering around the storage room, feeling like a million bucks, smugly asking Adora to tie her bowtie (just to untie it again five minutes later...)

Smiling at these memories, Adora thinks about her old friends and how much time they really spent together. Even practicing a dumb, irrelevant dance routine was a nice break from the monotony of combat training, and she has to admit it - Catra was right, the suit didn't hurt either…

No! Focus! Get your head in the game, Adora! She's just trying to get under your skin; you know that. Do ***not*** *give her the satisfaction. Show her that you aren't here to mess around - that you mean business.*

Adora straightens up, catching up with Catra's pace. "So, where to next? Which part of the Princess Prom are you gonna ruin first?"

Ugh. Weak. Get it together, Adora; come on.

"Hmm, I don't know, I was thinking maybe I'd go hang out with Entrapta some more. We really hit it off, ya know - you might actually have some competition now. Plus now that you're gone, *someone's* gonna have to help me with my bowtie," she glances back at Adora, pausing for effect.

Adora groans, suppressing how much she wants to ask what exactly Catra meant by that.

"Oh, shut up! Besides, I don't think Entrapta even knows *how* to tie a bowtie…" she trails off.

"Oh, so you're saying that I *need* you? Is that why you've been following me around all night?"

"No, that's not- what?" Adora shakes her head in confusion. Catra is just so good at throwing her off, distracting her, making her forget why she's doing this in the first place. How was she so good at getting in her head and muddling everything up?!

"No, Catra, that wasn't the point. The point is that you're *obviously* here for a reason, and I'm willing to bet it's nothing good."

Overcome with a sudden wave of rageful frustration; Adora grabs Catra's shoulders and pins her against the wall, snarling. "Just *tell me what is going on already!* " she shouts.

In a blur of movement, Catra escapes from Adora's death grip and ducks under her arm.

"Hey! Leave me alone!"

"Not before you tell me what you're *planning* !" Adora shoves Catra on the last word, knocking her back into one of the hallway's many closed doors.

With a sudden ***crack*** the door flies open, and the two tumble onto the ground of what seems like a supply closet. Their chaotic grand entrance causes a few things to fly off the metal shelves

and land with a crash on top of the girls, now struggling to get their bearings and find their balance amidst the crowded closet.

Yelling vague insults at each other, they push off the empty buckets and toilet paper rolls as they try to stand up in the dimly lit supply room. Adora stumbles over the corner of a box on the ground and falls back into the door, pushing it closed again. Angrily facing Catra, she looks down and points to a small tear in the bottom of her red dress.

"Oh great! Thanks a lot, Catra! This isn't even *mine* , and now when I give it back I have to explain why I *ruined* it within the first hour of the event!"

"What?! This isn't even my fault! *You* pushed *me* into the door, in case you forgot! And your dress is nothing compared to *this* !" Catra holds out the corner of her collar, showing Adora the blotchy black stain her suit got during the fall. "This was my *favorite* suit, and now it's *ruined* !"

Adora feels the anger subside in her chest, suddenly replaced with regret and sadness. Catra was right; she was the one who pushed her into the door. And Catra really did love that suit.

"Catra, I'm- I'm sorry…"

"No you're not."

"Yes, I am, really - let me make it up to you," Adora begins to nervously fumble around the nearest shelf, looking for some sort of stain removal or cleaning agent that might help the stain.

Wanting the night to be over already, Catra reaches out and stills Adora's arms.

(Ugh. Even when she's the ***enemy*** *, she still cares.)*

"Adora, really, it's fine. I never really wear this suit anymore, anyway…" she trails off.

Adora looks down at her feet, the reality of their positions on opposite sides of a war hitting her once again. They stand in heavy silence for a few moments, looking awkwardly down at the floor.

"Hey!" Adora exclaims, bending down to pick up a bottle on the bottom shelf of a metal shelving unit. "Instant stain remover!"

"What?"

"Help me find a cloth!"

"Adora, stop already, I told you it's fine-"

"No, here, look!" Adora grabs a raggedy cleaning cloth from a clean pile of linens, moving closer to Catra with a proud grin on her face. "I can still fix it!"

Catra sighs and looks away, considering the offer. "Fine," she crosses her arms, "but you get one try. And I'm only doing this because I really like this suit."

Adora raises her eyebrow, a silent *Oh really?* playing behind her expression.

Catra rolls her eyes. " *Not* because I like you."

Adora leans forward after spraying the rag with a generous amount of the stain remover, taking the collar from Catra's tight grip. Catra's face scrunches with awkwardness as Adora leans in and begins to scrub, looking at the rag between scrubs to see if the remover was really lifting up the stain.

"Any luck?"

"Yeah, actually, it's starting to come out a little. Just give me a few more minutes," Adora's tongue pokes out over the corner of her top lip as she works.

"You having fun there, Princess?" Catra teases.

"Ok, you know what, do you want my help or not?" Adora asks, stopping to put her hands on her hips.

Catra sighs, reaching up to make the motion of 'locking' her lips and 'throwing' away the key.

"That's what I thought," Adora says, continuing her work.

As she rubs the cloth against Catra's collar, Adora feels the heat in her chest begin to blossom like it did the night before. Part of her had wished she could be this close to Catra again someday; she just didn't realize that day would be *today* .

Nonetheless, part of her now wishes they could stay here all night, talking things out, possibly deciding that *both* of them should head back to Bright Moon together after the Prom…

"You okay there, bud?" Catra's voice snaps Adora out of her brief daydream, and she realizes that at some point she stopped rubbing the stain, instead just staring at Catra's neck in silence, her hands resting on Catra's upper chest.

Adora's face flushes with heat. "Y-yeah, sorry, I was just thinking."

"Thinking about what? Seems like you visited another planet for a sec there."

"I was just thinking," Adora speaks slowly and purposefully, "that this is kind of… nice. It's nice to just get a break from all the noise of the party once in a while."

"Oh. Yeah, I guess," Catra agrees reluctantly.

She hates that she momentarily considered ditching the plan and going home with Adora.

She looks down at Adora's arms, tense muscles working the fabric with a consistent rhythm, her strong hands pressing Catra back into the wall as she focuses on the stain. A sudden jolt of excitement and longing rushes down her chest as she briefly

imagines one of Adora's hands wrapped around her neck, the other…

"Alright, almost done," Adora says, snapping Catra out of her own head.

Catra looks down at her collar. "You got it out?"

"I mean, I did the best I could, and I think I did it. We'll have to wait for it to dry a little more before we know for sure. Right now, it's kind of just… really, really wet… almost dripping. My bad," Adora says sheepishly. "Guess I rubbed it a little too much."

Catra bites her lip, trying to ignore how Adora's words might or might not have just made her soaking wet herself.

Out of nowhere, Adora raises her hands back up to Catra's neck, grabbing either end of the bowtie and slowly starting to tie it for her. Catra freezes in disbelief, not wanting to stop her but dreading how close Adora is getting to her face. Dangerously close.

Adora's fingers fumble and she looks up at Catra, a goofy smile making its way onto her blushing face. "Guess I haven't done this in a while, heh. Let me try again."

Adora smoothes out the fabric on Catra's chest, undoing whatever she'd tied together the first time.

She gently traces the fabric up and around Catra's neck, making sure it isn't twisted in the back before continuing. Catra feels her core tense, anticipation making her abdomen buzz with heat. She feels herself get even wetter when Adora starts tying again, looking up at Catra with a smile that could melt the coldest of glaciers.

Adora's fingers continue fiddling with the knot, but if she's honest with herself, at this point she's not in any rush to succeed. Taking every chance she gets to let her fingertips subtly graze Catra's hot bare skin, Adora savors the way Catra's body betrays her and

leans into Adora’s touch, the rise and fall of her chest quickening as her breathing deepens with pleasure. Adora thinks to herself that the room feels hotter. The growing tension holds them both captive to their desires as they stand inches apart against the wall, Adora’s hands now barely moving at all.

Adora looks up to meet Catra’s eyes.

What she sees almost makes her gasp out loud.

Catra stares back at her with the hunger of an animal, the desperate plea of a lover. Her stare bores into Adora’s, making its way down through her chest, culminating as a throb between her legs. Catra doesn’t move, doesn’t blink - she just stares back at Adora, a primal desire aflame on her face, uncontrollable heat pooling between her legs.

It’s obvious what she wants.

Adora grips the two ends of the failed bowtie and presses Catra back into the wall, leaning in and finally connecting their lips with the furious passion of someone who’s wanted to do this for a long, long time.

Catra yips out in surprise, eventually relaxing into the kiss and pulling Adora’s body into hers, instinctively letting her legs open for Adora’s thigh to slot in between. Adora sighs into Catra’s mouth, feeling the release of tension beg her for more, more, *more* of Catra. She runs her fingers up Catra's back, nestling them at the base of her ears, drinking in Catra's soft gasp, the sound of a purr beginning to roll around in her chest. Adora smiles to herself and digs her fingers into Catra's hair, pulling her closer, absorbing the vibrations emanating from Catra's abdomen as her purring grows more and more intense. Catra's tail winds around to grip Adora's thigh, wrapping around it and inching upward.

Catra feels Adora go wonderfully weak in the knees for a moment, as a result of her teasing.

Feeling Adora’s lips part with a moan, Catra deepens the kiss, letting their tongues dance in perfect tandem before she clumsily wraps her arms around Adora’s neck. Catra feels the hot desperation grow in her groin as she presses her body into Adora’s, moaning softly into Adora’s open mouth as Adora presses her thigh even harder between Catra’s legs.

Adora’s strong arms finally lift Catra up against the wall with a sudden, powerful adjustment. Catra’s legs wrap around Adora’s hips as she grinds down even harder against her, searching for any kind of pressure or friction, some sort of release, some way to satisfy the insatiable hunger blossoming between her legs.

Adora suddenly pulls away from the kiss, a smug grin splayed across her blushing face. The twinkle in her eye tells Catra that she is utterly in charge, completely in control - that Catra’s body is hers to do with as she pleases.

Fuckkk.

Catra clenches her legs and feels another wave of arousal pulse through her body as Adora leans in, whispering fiercely in her ear:

“Follow me.”

Chapter End Notes

thank you so so much for reading!! writing this has been so fun and I don't intend on stopping anytime soon!
please leave a comment if you feel inclined to do so, it really means so so much to me to know people like what I make :]
have a wonderful day!

cool blue

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora make the most of their alone time at Princess Prom...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Follow me."

Catra nods quickly and silently, entirely at the mercy of the devious energy crackling behind Adora's eyes. Her core feels tight and hot at the idea of Adora deciding what happens next - the sweet exhilaration of belonging to her, if only for just a brief snapshot in time, making her weak in the knees and dizzy in the head. Taking Catra's hand and giving it a quick squeeze, Adora leans her head out the closet door to check if the hallway is clear.

"Come on," she whispers, "I know somewhere we can go to be alone."

Catra tries to hide the crooked smile on her face, charmed by the idea that Adora probably has Frosta's castle memorized by now, given that she most likely studied it beforehand. It would be like Adora to have some obsessively elaborate map set up in her room in an effort to prepare for the Prom and all its potential outcomes. She briefly imagines Adora pacing back and forth, deep in thought, tracing the pad of her finger over a hand-drawn map of the castle, concentration pinching her brow as she quietly mumbles to herself the names and locations of each room.

And here I am, about to mess it all up.

Catra shakes the thought out of her head, refocusing on the moment at hand. Besides, she's earned a little fun after all the work she did to prepare for today. This is just the cherry on top. She bites the inside of her cheek in firm resolution to let the chips fall where they may; today she was going to come out on top no matter what.

Heh.

Dragging Catra by the wrist down the hallway, Adora peeks around the corner to scan the dancefloor for anyone who might notice and question their being together. Motioning that the coast is clear, she and Catra snake along the edge of the auditorium, slipping like shadows down another icy, dim corridor.

"Where are we going?" Catra hisses, getting more nervous by the second. "People are going to notice we've been gone." She glances back at a clock in the hallway. Yeah, she's definitely got time.

"Just wait, you'll see," Adora smirks, rushing down the hallway. She doesn't quite know what's come over her, why she's throwing caution to the wind while on a very important diplomatic mission by mingling with the enemy. - *Heh. Mingling. That's one way to put it.* - But the idea of never having this chance again, of never finding a way to be alone with Catra again, convinces her that this is just too good an opportunity to pass up. So what if she's a little irresponsible for once? If she dips away from the drama and the action and takes some time for herself? The hero of the world needs a break every once in a while, right?

...right?

Making their way deeper and deeper into the castle, quietly winding through halls and corridors and slipping past large empty

rooms, the girls finally arrive at the entrance of what seems to be the guest quarters - where diplomatic visitors of the Kingdom of Snows can reside during their stay.

“I think this is it,” Adora turns to face Catra, face alive with excitement. “According to the map of the castle, we should be able to have some privacy over here…”

Catras’s heart smiles at how well she knows Adora, all her quirks and habits and tendencies.

She totally called it.

Her heart sinks when she remembers that Adora probably has other maps hung up around her room to help her plan how to fight off the Horde - how to fight off Catra. A guilty grimace makes its way onto her face.

Turning to face Catra, Adora raises a confused eyebrow. “Hey, are you okay? We don’t have to do this, you know.”

“No! No, I want to, I just - I don’t want to get kicked out-” Catra imagines Lonnie and Kyle with the Sword of Protection, how they’re all supposed to be in position in an hour. She winces at the thought of betraying Adora like this, but then again, this is the only way. Things couldn’t be any different, even if - even though - she wants them to be. In the end, there’s just no other way.

Noticing a trace of panic on Catra’s downturned face, Adora’s eyes widen with fear, horrified by the thought having made Catra uncomfortable.

“Catra, I’m so sorry, I shouldn't have rushed it. I just thought we should have some privacy, that we should do this the right way, that’s all. But if you don’t want to do this anymore, that’s totally okay, and we can just go back t-”

Snapping out of it with a jolt, Catra grabs Adora’s arms, pressing her back against the icy blue wall.

"No. We're doing this."

Bang -

the door rattles against its frame as Catra's back slams against it; Adora's arms on her hips, pinning her back against the hard wooden panel, Adora's mouth hot against her neck, the slight graze of a bite here and there, a moan caught in her dry throat, her left arm blindly feeling for the lock - ***click .***

Adora pulls away from Catra's neck, grabbing her wrists and sliding them up the door, pinning them together against the surface - she drinks in the sight of Catra's body displayed before her, the curve of her waist beneath her suit.

God, that damn suit.

One hand makes its way slowly down Catra's arm, a nail trailing its way across her chest and down her abdomen. Adora's hot breath leans in closer to Catra's ear; she hears Catra suck in a breath as she whispers -

"I've waited so long to see you like this."

Catra's chest rises in anticipation, a bead of sweat racing down the side of her neck.

Adora looks at Catra as she pulls her head away, Catra's eyes alight with something Adora has seen a hundred times before… but never like this.

"No," Catra says, "I've waited forever to see *you* like this."

Adora tilts her head, an eyebrow following suit. "Oh, is that s-"

Before Adora can finish her sentence, Catra yanks her hands out from under Adora's grip and slams Adora back against the door, effectively switching their positions in the blink of an eye.

Adora's mouth hangs open in surprise, a gasp silenced by the sudden wave of heat pooling between her legs as Catra holds her against the door.

A few steamy more kisses until Catra swoops Adora up with one quick motion, forcing her legs to wrap around Catra's middle.

A breathy moan escapes Adora's mouth as Catra carries her over to a neatly-made bed in the corner of the room, kissing her ferociously and feeling up her ass while she walks. Who knew she was so strong?

The guest room is nice and roomy and cool, dimly lit by a back wall seemingly made of ice - a soft cool blue glow is cast across the basic furniture and amenities. The ice wall isn't entirely flat, rendering it almost a decoration in and of itself; the translucent blue a magnificent complement to the dark brown wood comprising the remainder of the room's color scheme. The entire space has a soft, *warm* feel to it - ironic, considering the wall of ice casting a hazy cold glow across the dark brown space.

Throwing Adora down on the bed, Catra takes off her suit jacket, pausing to wink at Adora in her dumbfounded, hypnotic state.

Yeah, she missed the suit.

She stares down at Adora; the way she leans up on her elbows, her wordless stare, the way her hair looks like she just walked through a wind tunnel, the ponytail so loose it's about to fall out, the deep red blush creeping over her already-flushed cheeks. It really is a breathtaking sight.

"Doesn't seem like you to be so excited about being out of control," Catra murmurs, "would've never thought the almighty She-ra would like being roughed around like that."

Adora smirks, quickly sitting up on the edge of the bed and gripping Catra's hips. "It seems I'm full of surprises then… cause I like being in control, too. Maybe you'll find out someday" she flashes Catra a look that says *Don't you believe for a second I'm a bottom; 'cause I'll switch if I want to.*

Catra, caught off guard by the not-so-subtle implication, feels her submissive side ache for a moment. An image of Adora walking toward a tied-up Catra and smacking a paddle in her hands flashes across her mind; she feels dizzy at the possibilities available to *two* switches.

- Wait, did Adora say *next time?*

"I see I caught you off guard there," Adora teases. "It seems even after all these years there's still a lot you don't know about me," her lilting voice is white hot and dripping with a smoky fullness; Catra feels the words shiver up her spine, the space between her legs suddenly feeling needy, aching for attention.

"Well in that case," Catra leans forward, slowly sliding her body in between Adora's trembling legs, drinking in the soft sigh she hears from above her. Her face sidles up next to Adora's, hot breath rustling the baby hairs behind her ears, "I'd better start educating myself."

Adora feels the fire in her stomach return with blazing fury, the heat making its way down her legs and up her spine as she lifts her body up against Catra's in desperation.

Adora closes her eyes as Catra's lips lower against her neck, starting slow with soft teases and gradually increasing in pressure and aggression, her fangs nipping at tender skin with restrained ferocity. Adora wraps her legs around Catra's waist as Catra begins to rhythmically grind against her, the movement slow and

methodical as Catra's kisses make their way up Adora's neck toward her mouth.

Adora's hands reach up around Catra's neck, pulling her closer with a needy whimper as Catra deepens their kiss, her tongue exploring Adora's mouth like it's an oasis in a merciless desert.

Suddenly, Catra pulls away, staring at Adora, lips slightly parted, her chest rising and falling as she tries to watch her breath. Her eyes fierce with a devious spark, she lifts an eyebrow and lifts Adora's arms over her head, pressing her fingers through the slats of the headboard.

Swiftly crawling back off the bed, Catra stands over Adora with a smirk. "Don't move, Princess."

Nodding in exhilarated confusion, Adora lays her head back down as Catra walks away toward the dresser. Adora stares at the ceiling, rubbing her legs together impatiently and realizing just how wet she already is. She hopes Catra would hurry up and stop teasing her already. Hasn't she been patient enough? She sighs.

Catra returns to the foot of the bed, holding up a fluffy white robe.

"I don't think Princess Frosta will mind if we borrow this," she says as she slides the soft belt out of the robe's middle section, dropping the rest on the floor. She then tugs off her outer garments, letting them drop simply to the ground. A matching set of a maroon sports bra and pair of boxers are all that's left hugging her curves, accentuating the hot tan skin beneath. Watching Adora's eyes hungrily trace down the curve of her waist, down her middle, and back up to her chest, Catra cocks an eyebrow and silently mounts the bed.

She's going to make Adora feel so good.

Straddling Adora's thighs with a grin, Catra looks down with determination. "Your turn… now be a *good girl* and take off your dress."

Adora gasps, the words like fire beneath her, lighting up her whole body with an unparalleled electric longing.

Good girl.

Catra smirks, proud of herself for getting Adora so riled up with just two simple words. *Because of course Adora would have a praise kink* , she thinks. *Why wouldn't she?*

Adora sits up and obediently pulls her dress over her head as Catra leans back, attentively watching the show. Adora's bra and panties are both a simple black, and she looks ridiculously sexy - her defined arm muscles tensing and pulsing as she works the dress over her head, her abdomen tensing gloriously with the tension, the slight damp glimmer of sweat across her skin, the way she grunts as she finally yanks the dress off her head and throws it across the room, her stare eager and obedient as she awaits another command. Catra feels another pulse of wet between her legs, imagining Adora's toned body tensing and moaning beneath Catra's touch. Being a good girl for her.

But there's no need to rush things.

They'll get there.

"Bra," Catra orders, and Adora rushes to obey.

Pulling the straps off her arms, Adora looks up at Catra with a tender vulnerability, a sudden nervousness alight in her chest once her full chest is completely revealed.

They both realize that although they've seen each other's bodies plenty of times before, it's never been quite like this, and the novelty adds to the electric tension between them.

Staring down at Adora's bare chest, Catra is breathless. She loses her focus and growling momentum for a moment, tracing a long, black nail around Adora's nipple, teasing it until it hardens.

Pressing her thumb against Adora's nipple, Catra's eyes widen with satisfaction as Adora moans and arches her back into her touch.

Focus.

"Hands," she says.

With immediate obedience, Adora sits up slightly and presses her wrists together in front of her, her heart racing as she submits to Catra's gruff commands.

Tying her wrists together, Catra cocks her head and looks at Adora with a grin. "Good girl."

Adora feels her clit pulse as she drinks in Catra's praise, surprised at how such a simple phrase could make her so unbelievably horny.

Good girl. Be a good girl.

Be a good girl for Catra.

Catra leans her back, fastening her hands to the headboard by tying the soft rope around the slats. Whispering in her ear, Catra checks for the go ahead:

"This okay?"

"Yeah, yes," Adora responds breathlessly.

"Hmm a little eager, are we Princess?" Catra hums.

This elicits a soft moan in response, Adora lifting her pelvis up in search of any kind of relief for the sudden pulse of needy arousal coursing through her pelvis.

Catra chuckles softly in Adora's ear, revelling in how utterly stupid she's made Adora.

"You tell me your safe word and trust me with the rest, okay?"

Adora nods a muffled whimper, Catra's sultry tone making her dizzy with excitement.

"Uhh maybe like, like green, yellow, red?" she suggests.

"Like go, slow down, stop?" Catra clarifies.

"Yeah," Adora says.

"Okay, now you leave the rest to me," Catra grins, resuming her fervent tying.

Adora's arms now securely fastened to the headboard, her body is restless with anticipation, every inch alive with heat and excitement.

Getting to work, Catra lowers herself down Adora's chest, her tongue teasing a soft pathway toward Adora's left nipple, eventually enveloping it and swirling around it with her rough tongue. Adora stifles an almost-yell, instead settling for a low whine as her eyes shut and her head leans back in pleasure. Almost dizzy with satisfaction, Adora rubs her legs together in desperation as Catra continues to suck and lightly tug at her hardened nipple.

"You've been a very good girl today," Catra hums into her chest, "you think you deserve a reward?"

Adora sighs and nods her head, once again lifting her hips up against the air in search of relief.

Catra giggles at Adora's silent plea, kissing her way down the hot skin of Adora's core. Pausing for a moment at the waistband of Adora's underwear, Catra feels a pulse of arousal at the idea of uncovering what lay beneath. Again, it's nothing new to see each other naked, but she's never seen Adora aroused like *this* before - and what's more, as a result of her touch.

Commanding Adora's body and mind with a simple touch, Catra revels in the control she's been given, drinking in the feeling of

being *utterly* in charge, able to do to Adora whatever she pleases.

Feeling Adora pull against her wrist constraints, Catra slides a nail beneath the thin black fabric below her.

She teases a few searing hot kisses down Adora's skin before letting the waistband snap back into place and leaning back on her knees, staring down at Adora with an intense, devilish stare. Adora groans in agony, realizing Catra will most likely make her work for what she wants.

"Sounds like you want something, Princess."

"Catra… please…"

"Ohh come on, you know I'm not that easy. Be a good girl and use your words. Catra, please… what?"

"Mmmh-" Adora squirms beneath Catra's agonizing stare, her body alive with heat, her underwear long past the point of keeping dry.

"Adora," Catra lowers herself over her, slotting their thighs together and grinding a slow body roll against her wet underwear as she brings her mouth up against Adora's ear, hot breath grazing the sensitive skin. "Be a good girl for me and *tell me what you want."*

"Fuck me," Adora blurts out, breathless and eager, her body up lifting up against Catra's. "Catra… f-fuck me. Now"

"Mmmmm," Catra sighs into her ear, "there's a good girl."

Snaking a hand down to Adora's underwear, Catra stares Adora in the eyes and traces a single tantalizing finger through the wet cloth, stopping with intention at the top of Adora's slit.

"Fuck, and already so wet for me," Catra says, watching Adora's mouth open with a silent gasp. "So wet and so desperate… it's

precious."

"A-aaahh-" Adora's body moves in waves against Catra's hand, her body begging Catra to take things all the way and *just fuck her already.*

Sliding beneath the black fabric, Catra's finger finally dips into Adora's soaking folds, surprised even still at just how ridiculously wet she's made her - the thought elicits an involuntary grind against Adora's thigh as Catra's own pussy begs for pressure and release.

Electric heat radiates up Adora's body, a breathy moan let out against Catra's mouth - she never thought anything *could feel this good*. Even her fantasies of this moment couldn't compare to the real thing - the cocky grin on Catra's face, the insatiable hunger in her eyes, her warm body pressing decidedly against Adora's, the ecstasy of a single curved finger slowly running its way over her throbbing clit… it's enough to make Adora gasp: desperately trying to take in the muchness of it all, trying to keep herself from reaching the summit before Catra even gets the chance to really fuck her, breathing deeply and steadily through the waves of pleasure wracking her body.

Catra's finger begins to tease her entrance, dipping in slightly and then returning to circle her clit again.

"Mmhhhh," Adora groans, her hips rising in desperate anticipation. "Catra…"

Catra slips a finger in, then two, in response - curving them expertly against Adora's g-spot. Pulsing a few times to warm her up, Catra begins to pump her fingers more and more quickly. Her mouth moves down to one of Adora's hardened nipples, licking it and taking it gently between her teeth for a slight pull. After sucking for a few moments, she moves back up, nipping below Adora's ear and sucking eagerly at the base of Adora's neck while her fingers continue to fuck Adora into the mattress. Adora pants shallow breaths as her whole body is consumed in the fire

emanating from between her legs, somewhere deep in her abdomen - her body arches and presses into Catra's magnificent hand, head pressed back against the headboard while Catra's tongue steadily travels up and down her neck.

"F-fuckkkkk," she moans toward the ceiling, the sounds of her own wetness turning her on even more.

"You like that, Princess?" Catra asks against Adora's neck while she pumps, feeling Adora pull her fingers in deeper with every thrust.

"Mmmhhhfuck," Adora pants, "don't stop -"

Aware that Adora is nearing the ledge, Catra pulls her fingers out and brings them up to Adora's mouth.

"Be a good girl and taste just how wet you are," Catra orders, pressing her fingertips against Adora's full lips. Taking in her fingers eagerly, Adora sucks tenderly and passionately her own wetness off Catra's fingers.

"Mmmh-good girl," Catra praises, staring into Adora's half-lidded eyes. "I'm going to make you come now. I think you've earned it."

A particularly strong suction around her fingers as Adora nods slightly, a deep sigh vibrating through her chest.

Pulling involuntarily at the headboard, Adora's breathing quickens as Catra kisses and nibbles down her aching body. Her pussy trembles against the heat of Catra's body, aching to be allowed to finish.

Catra slides two nails under each side of Adora's underwear, sliding them down Adora's soft legs and throwing them to the side. Grabbing each knee, she forces Adora open, slowly kissing down one thigh and then the other.

The swirl of Catra's tongue against her inner thigh drives Adora crazy, a soft moan caught as a low vibration in her throat as she

rolls her hips up against Catra's presence.

Finally, Catra lowers her head down into Adora's heat, a flat, rough tongue licking up her slit and stopping to focus briefly on her clit.

"A-aahh," Catra hears from above her, Adora's thighs clenching on either side of her head. She drags a hand up to Adora's breast, grabbing hold of it and working it in tandem with Adora's swollen clit.

"There's my good girl," Catra says against Adora's wetness, her mouth rhythmically working her into a desperate, dripping, mess. Her other hand grips at the indent of Adora's hip, digging her fingers into the fold as Adora rolls against Catra's face, the desperation between her legs growing.

Time slows as Catra's tongue works, hungrily tasting Adora's salty sweetness; her soft, dripping folds the most powerful of drugs for Catra's determined fervor.

Catra's hand begins tracing circles around Adora's nipple, teasing it with the occasional press or flick as she looks up at Adora, eyes ablaze with devilish intent.

"Now come for me."

"Ffffffuckk," Adora's thighs begin to tremble, her legs tensing and lifting as she nears orgasm, a new wave of wetness greeting Catra's mouth at her entrance in anticipation.

Catra tightens her grip on Adora's hip and breast as she continues to lap up Adora's delicious juices, a stubborn resolve making its way to the forefront of her mind as she watches Adora shiver with pleasure.

"I said," she growls into Adora,

" *come for me.* "

"Aahh… ah- fuck-" Adora whimpers, her breath shallow and hot, her body entirely at the mercy of Catra's command. She feels the delicious pressure against her clit increase as she grinds down desperately against Catra's mouth, a wave of ecstasy flooding her body as sweet release races up her abdomen. Riding out the waves of the most intense orgasm she's ever had, Adora's vision blurs for a moment, her mouth slightly parted in silent breathlessness.

"Hmmmm good girl," Catra praises, holding Adora through the aftershocks, her tongue held still so as not to overwhelm Adora's senses or distract her from the intensity of the climax.

Adora's legs slowly calm their trembling, now only an occasional twitch shivering its way down the length of her body as she pants, trying to catch her breath.

"Fuck," Catra observes after a moment of simply holding Adora, her face frozen with pleasant surprise pressed against Adora's thigh, "you really came."

Adora looks down in playful shock, watching Catra climb up toward the headboard. "Uhh, yeah - what, are you surprised??"

Untying Adora's wrists with gentle precision, Catra gives the red marks a soft rub before letting her arms go. "I mean, I don't know, just - like, how did we get here?" she huffs in pleasant disbelief.

Adora smiles a goofy grin as she watches Catra collapse down on the bed, eventually propping herself up on a shaky elbow. "I mean… I'm not surprised," Adora says, "it was bound to happen sometime, right?"

Catra's eyes widen, a blush creeping across her cheeks. "You think so?"

"Catra, you *kissed* me last night. What did you think that meant??"

"I don't know! It was just instinct! I didn't think you'd really let me in like that!" she exclaims as Adora leans her head back in a playful laugh.

Catra stares at Adora, her eyes devouring the beautiful, toned body laying next to her, processing the remarkable honor she feels at having had the chance to get to be close to Adora like that. (And who would've thought they'd be so compatible in bed??)

A small, tender smile creeps its way into her face at the idea that even after all this time, Adora trusts her to have control like that, to put her in such a vulnerable position even though they are enemies on the opposite side of a war. Could there be a chance things don't have to be this way?

"Well, if I'm remembering correctly," Adora interrupts Catra's mindless staring, "I'm pretty sure it's your turn now…"

Adora sits up on her knees, an eyebrow raised as she smirks down at Catra's reddening cheeks. Her hands reach up to tighten the ponytail now holding on for dear life at the end of her hair, a determined heat pooling in her chest. Now it was her turn to be in charge, show Catra what she's made of…

When Catra opens her mouth to respond, a harsh series of knocks on the guest room door rudely interrupts her. Both girls jump in surprise at the sudden sound, their heads whipping to stare at the shadow underneath the door.

"Hey, is someone in here?" a gruff voice calls from the hallway. "The Guest Chambers are strictly off limits until 8pm," it barks.

Catra and Adora look at each other, eyes wide with panic.

It seems Catra’s turn will have to wait.

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for reading, once again - and leave a comment if you feel so inclined, I love love love the feedback! :]

wings of wax

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra wrestle with the very real consequences of what they've just done.

Chapter Notes

hey guys, I'm so sorry took me so long to update. thought I'd add the next chapter on the 1-year mark of the last one so we can kinda just try and pick up where we left off. I never meant to abandon this, I promise - life kinda just fell apart all of a sudden and I had to focus on just wanting to stay alive for a while I guess. anyway thanks for reading my stuff at all, it means a lot to me. <3 ok I'll shut up now enjoy chapter 6 :]
edit, 1 April 23: just thought i'd let y'all know i've decided to let this rest as the final chapter of the fic. the weight of reviving it makes me waaay too anxious, and i'd like to be able to move my focus to other fandoms i've become obsessed with in the past few years lol. maybe it'll get revived someday, maybe not, depends on if people are dying for a ch.7 - who knows. but for now, you've reached the end! thanks for reading. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It seems Catra's turn will have to wait.

Another sharp knock rattles the door, the shadow on the floor shifting slightly in the crack beneath the frame. "Hello? I know somebody's in there, I heard voices!"

“U-uhh - yes, sorry, just - just one minute!” Adora panics, turning to Catra with an exasperated shrug.

“You’ve *got* to be kidding me,” Catra hisses, sliding off the bed with a huff and snatching her clothes off the floor.

The voice calls out again, this time harsher and more pointed. “I’m going to have to ask you to leave the guest quarters immediately. They are strictly off limits while the Princess Prom is still in session.”

“Okay, yes, we get it, we’re coming!” Catra snaps.

Adora glances at her with a crooked smile while slipping into her dress, whispering to Catra while she smooths the fabric -

“Well… I mean, that *was* the plan… buttttttttttt… ”

Catra rolls her eyes with a defeated grin, the blush still creeping up her cheeks. Adora looks so beautiful like this - a goofy smile lighting up her face; the childlike excitement at having broken the rules causing her eyes to widen with a playful defiance.

Catra used to love it when she could talk Adora into breaking the rules - she always got the same look in her eye, and it always made Catra’s heart leap in her chest, just as it does now.

And then… the weirdest thing happens.

As she begins slipping into her suit jacket and pulling her mane of hair out the back, a sudden wave of guilt and fear floods her chest. It’s dense, and heavy; like lead.

Catra tries desperately to fight the searing panic rising up in her throat. She’d been caught.

She *knew* this was risky from the start, and she did it anyway - and now the *entire* operation might crash and fail just because she couldn't say no to… to what, exactly? to a stupid temptation? to a selfish fantasy?

Really - what *did* she risk this all for anyway? a cheap hookup with an old friend - no, enemy! - for the sake of hashing out past "feelings"?

Catra bites down on her inner cheek to keep hot tears from streaming down her face.
*You're so fucking stupid. You are **so** fucking stupid.*

Now dressed and frantically grooming themselves into looking half presentable, the two rush over to the door, the dark wood swinging open with a ***whoosh*** .

A large, cloaked figure emerges in the doorframe, holding a blue staff and wearing a stoic frown. He glances over the girls standing awkwardly in front of him before carefully scanning the room behind them, looking for anything outwardly suspicious.

"What are you two doing down here?"

Adora steps forward, lightly clasping her hands in front of her chest. "Sorry - uh, sir - we..."

"We got lost," Catra interrupts, "that's all. We'll be on our way now, thanks." Pinching Adora's upper arm as a signal to *go* , she slips past the guard into the hallway.

There's still time. She can still fix this. She's got time.

As they scurry away, Adora glances back to see the guard throw them a curious glance as he begins to inspect the room.

Oops.

"Well, that was close," Adora mumbles, looking over at Catra with a devious smile, "buuuuut so worth it." She gently nudges Catra with her shoulder.

Catra stares at the ground, her face twisted with - discomfort? regret? Adora bites her lip and looks straight ahead.

The two walk a ways in silence, the distant echo of party music emanating through the icy castle walls. Catra leads with a quickening pace, although they both know she's got no idea where she's going.

Now fearing she might have overdone it and pushed things too fast, Adora hesitantly lays a hand on Catra's shoulder.

"Catra? Um… you okay?"

"Yes, I'm fine," she snaps, swatting Adora's hand back. Her stone-cold stare continues to bore into the ground, avoiding Adora trying to catch up to her.

"Hey," Adora comes to an abrupt halt in the dim, empty hallway - arms crossed, face stern with worry. "What the hell's going on with you?"

"Nothing. I said I'm *fine* ," Catra stops but doesn't turn around. Her hands are balled into fists. "Can we please just get back to the dance?"

"Catra, how stupid do you think I am? I can tell something's going on with you, just talk to me."

"Will you just *drop it* ?!" Catra whips around, arms raised in anger. Her gaze meets Adora's and for a second, Adora fears it'll slice

right through her - but Catra drops it to the floor before she can find out.

"Are you- are you *mad* at me?" Her mouth hangs slightly open as her head cocks gently to the side, subtly trying to make eye contact with Catra.

"No! …yes? I don't know, I just… like, what; are we just supposed to just… go back to normal now? Adora, what are we *doing* ?" The panic swells up in Catra's chest and, for a brief moment, she feels like she might actually start crying.

Adora stares at her in silence, her face twisted with - anger? hurt? betrayal?

Catra's face wrinkles with frustration and panic, her brow furrowing as the anger begins to take over.

Adora pulls her bottom lip into her mouth and stares at the ground, too. Honestly, she understands why Catra's so upset. After what just happened, how *are* they supposed to go back to hating each other?

Because the only other option would be changing things, and Adora can't imagine that would go smoothly - even if Catra *could* change her mind, it wouldn't really matter. What could "changing things" even *mean* when Catra's so out of control of… well, everything?

And of course, all the pressure is on Catra. Adora *has* told her numerous times how badly she wants her to join the Rebellion; all she's waiting on is an answer.

She can almost *see* the conflict tearing Catra in half.

It's too late.

Her heart sinks into her stomach as she briefly considers the devastating possibility that Catra might not have even wanted to sleep with her in the first place - that she might have planned on using Adora's obvious feelings for her as a distraction, or a way to mess with her head, or a way to get her in trouble with the guards of Snows.

Her face turns red with embarrassment at the idea and she fights back the lump rising in her throat, shaking the thought away and telling herself Catra would never, ever do that to her. Even now.

But then again… would she?

Breaking the silence between them, another guard - significantly shorter and scrawnier than the one from before - passes them in the dark hallway. Adora briefly wonders what a royal guard is doing patrolling the random side corridor the two of them found momentary solace and privacy in, but forgets about it once she thinks she sees him exchange a slow, tense look with Catra as he passes…

What the hell was that about?

The guard rounds a corner and disappears, and Adora snaps out of it, returning her attention to the situation in front of her - the air between them getting colder by the second.

Catra stares tensely at the ground, an arm reaching up to gingerly hold her opposite elbow.

You need to get out of here, Catra - what are you doing?! Kyle just confirmed that it's go time soon and you need to get into position! ***Go!***

But no matter how hard she tries, Catra cannot seem to get her feet to move - not a single inch. She is utterly paralyzed; glued to the icy, translucent floor of the castle as the thoughts begin to swarm again; begin to flood her with reminders that she is stupid and worthless and fucks everything up.

This was not how this night was supposed to go.

Adora frowns, the guilt beginning to take over again.

She looks so small; so… vulnerable? Even with the suit and the mask - even with the snarl creeping onto her face - she's still just my Catra.

Adora steps a bit closer, stealing Catra's gaze from the floor (and unknowingly interrupting her internal spiral.)

"Look, Catra -" Adora pauses, calculating her next words very carefully. "I didn't mean to push you. I'm sorry. I'm sorry I- that I've been-" Adora huffs in frustration, the right words getting caught in her throat.

Are there even words for this?

She continues in desperation.

"And I'm really sorry this is all so… weird. I don't really know what to do now either. I'm sorry you had to go through all this just because I- because of my choices. I know this has been hell for you and I just wish there was an easier way…" *Alright. That'll have to do.*

"I don't *need* you to be *sorry* !" Catra explodes, suddenly pushing Adora back - frenzied, like an animal backed into a corner. "And I *definitely* don't need your *pity* ," Catra spits as Adora stands frozen in shock. Hot tears begin to well up in her eyes. "I *need* this to be *over* " - her voice cracks, chest rising and falling with furious breaths.

Adora's mouth hangs open in genuine shock as she watches a tear stream down Catra's face. "Need what to be over?"

"I… *This!* I can't do *this* anymore, Adora!" Catra gestures aggressively to the both of them. She's not sure what exactly she means either, but she stands tall, holding her ground - ready for a fight.

Her and Adora's *emotional entanglement* has made this mission so much harder than it needed to be, and the stress is just too much. The cognitive dissonance is tearing her apart - when what she really needs is to *focus* .

No more of this "living in the middle" bullshit, especially with so much on the line. It's now or never.

She *will* complete this mission, and Adora *will* see what she is capable of - and, even if it's the last fucking thing she does, she *will* have the last laugh. Adora will be sorry she ever left her.

"Catra, we-"

"No, Adora. There is no 'we.'" Catra crosses her arms, eyes cold and unwavering. "There never was."

Catra turns and walks away, leaving Adora stunned in the hallway, thinking Gods-know-what. She doesn't fucking care what she thinks anymore.

Everyone else will be in final position pretty soon now that they had Bow, and they were still on for the scheduled exit time. Kyle's face said everything she needed to know.

Yeah, this plan is definitely going to work. And Catra is finally going to get the credit she deserves.

She stops and thinks, attention now entirely recentered on the mission: when the bombs blow, she has to keep Adora as busy as

possible so she can't get in the way of Catra and their friends making their final daring escape… and right now, the dance floor is definitely the best way to ensure she's distracted.

A smug, indignant flame ignites deep in her chest.

She grits her teeth and hopes she's going the right way.

Adora arrives on the second floor balcony, the numbing hum of the bass pounding in her ears. She looks around for Catra, but doesn't see her anywhere. And honestly, she can't care less right now. She wishes she could crawl in a hole and never come out.

Gods, even with only a few seconds lead on me, she still *manages to outrun - outwalk?! - me…*

Interrupting her train of thought, two party guests grab her by the arms and drag her down the stairs as a new song starts and Frosta announces the first formal dance of the evening.

And - oh gods.

Oh gods, she knows this one.

Oh, how she knows this one.

Flashbacks of her and Catra's informal-formal-dance-lessons-with-Kyle era swarm her head as her heart races along with the memory.

An escape from the harsh soldier's life they all had to pretend they wanted, the pressure to perform well, and Shadow Weaver's

constant berating, the dance lessons provided a rare and sacred chance to just *Be* - and to Be together.

There, in that cluttered, almost-forgotten room in the Fright Zone, the young cadets allowed themselves to just be… friends.

Still being pushed onto the dance floor, Adora feels dizzy as she remembers when she and Catra first practiced the dip at the end of this song - Catra's smiling face above hers; the blush that rushed to both of their cheeks; the silent, comfortable stare they shared that simply and silently assured the other ' *I don't know what's happening right now either, but I like it, and I'm going to trust that you do too.'*

Upon remembering the dip, Adora stiffens like a board, hoping to be able to rush out before the crowd and her social obligations force her to participate - but before she knows it, there she is: standing on the ballroom floor amidst a crowd of guests, nervously watching them pair up and prepare for the dance to start. And just like that, she doesn't really have a choice anymore.

A partially-gloved hand appears in front of her face.

Oh fuck.

Catra gives her a brief " *What, you scared?* " look, her arm still outstretched - and, never one to back down from a dare, and still trying her best to blend into the Princess crowd, Adora begrudgingly obliges.

The music picks up and the pair prepare to dance. Hand in hand, they begin - the first steps easy enough. (*Just lean and sway, Adora, focus! Show her how it doesn't affect you, even a little bit! This is your chance to get the situation under control again! Just… breathe… breathe, and remember. After all, the two of you have done this a thousand times…*)

Circling one another for the intro, Adora becomes increasingly aware of how close their bodies are and feels her cheeks flush with anticipatory heat against her will.

Slightly flustered now, she reluctantly remembers how - no more than 24 hours ago - she and Catra were in their own little world, far away from anything that could tear them apart… safe in the haven that had always existed between them but that is now so very far away ever since the chasm of anger and grief grew even deeper in light of… recent events.

But no matter how frustrated Adora gets; no matter how Catra pushes her away; no matter all the times Catra snaps her heart in two; she just can't escape that infinite, aching tenderness that creeps into her chest whenever she looks at her - and even now, even as they hate-dance through the crowd, Catra is still just so beautiful.

Catra smirks, catching the look in Adora's eyes and seemingly reading her mind. While she's vulnerable, she throws out a quick sarcastic jab -

"I don't know about you, but I am having a blast," she grips Adora's hand tighter, resting a firm hand on her hip as Adora does the same.

Adora's breath catches in her throat as they grab each other's hips. Catra even gives her a tight squeeze, reminding her how much control she still has over the mighty She-ra.

Gods, is it annoying… (and, admittedly, a little- *no* , no, that's all. Just annoying.)

Catra is so *fucking* annoying.

Trying desperately to regain the upper hand (and remembering that Catra is now probably definitely going to kill her if she gets the chance) Adora makes a weak attempt at changing the subject:

"Whatever it is you're planning, it won't work."

She makes sure the scowl on her face is a nasty one, to show Catra she means business (and that she wasn't *at all* affected by the hip squeeze.)

"You sure?" Catra retorts, before the two revel in a moment of tension and eventually turn away for the exchange of partners. (You know what? Hate dancing might be kind of fun.)

But then, dancing with Glimmer and Perfuma, Adora learns with horror that Bow is missing - and that nobody's seen him for… well, for far too long for this not to be a bad thing.

A very, very bad thing.

Catra slams back into Adora's chest, the full weight of her body almost knocking Adora over.

"Maybe my plan won't work… but, then again," her hand clamps Adora's onto her shoulder as she looks up with a smirk, her eyes hardened with determination and - is that a twinge of hatred?

And in that moment - in that blip of time, on the dance floor, at Princess Prom, in the Kingdom of Snows - Adora has a devastating

realization. Time seems to slow, her eyes widening in horror as it hits her:

It *was* a trick. All of it. *All* of it.

All part of the masterfully crafted plot Catra schemed up to play with Adora's head while she somehow kidnapped Bow… all a ploy for Catra to gain control, to gain power - she only thing she ever really wanted from Adora.

Showing up at the treehouse on the *exact* night Adora happened to decide to visit; luring her back into their old friendship with a little bit of fake vulnerability; making her think that the cuddling *meant* something to her; pretending to care about her well-being by leaving a note about the broken board (which Adora had stupidly put under her pillow for safe keeping); kissing her in the closet; making her feel beautiful, and safe, and wanted; holding her tight, as if she actually lov-

No .

Adora's breath hitches in her chest - she *feels* her heart break in half.

" *Maybe my plan won't work - but, then again* …"

The moment of dread slips away as Adora slams back into reality.

Catra stares back at Adora, arrogant malice aflame in her gaze. In one swift movement, she spins Adora and dips her between her legs, their thighs pressed warm and tight against each other, Catra grinning deviously at the trembling Adora beneath her (for the second time today) -

They send an icy shiver down Adora's spine, the words that mark the final nail in the coffin of what could have been:

“Maybe it already has.”

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading :] should post the next chapter before a year goes by... we'll see lol
edit, 1 April 23: read the note at the beginning of the chapter if you haven't yet hehe :] farewell!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!